

CITY: Pg 3
CM distributes bicycles to 200 girl students under 'Vidya Vahini'



NATION: Pg 5
Lok Sabha MPs of NCP (SP) meet PM Modi, discuss Maha issues



FILM: Pg 14
'Everybody is a product of their conditioning'



JHARKHAND JOB EXAM

Protesters, police claim injuries as lathi-charge, tear gas mark march to Assembly

'Use of force is wrong': Rahul Gandhi on Jharkhand student protest crackdown

MPOST BUREAU

RANCHI: Several protesters and four policemen were injured during a clash near the Jharkhand Assembly on Monday, as police used water cannons, tear gas and lathi-charged job aspirants protesting against alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations.

The clash took place after the protesters breached multiple barricades near the Jharkhand Vidhan Sabha.

The police action against the protesters mirrored the police crackdown on student protesters in Delhi last month as they led a march to Parliament.

Several protesters claimed they were injured in the police action, which took place when they reached the final barricade near Jagannathpur Temple on the road to the Assembly. Underscoring that peaceful protest is a right, Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi condemned the use of force against protesting students in Jharkhand, acting as a counterweight to the criticism against his INDIA bloc ally.

The comments came as the BJP has repeatedly criticised Gandhi over his "silence" on the students' protest in Jharkhand, which is ruled by the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM), an ally of Congress in the INDIA bloc.

"The use of force against students protesting in Jharkhand



An aerial view of students and job aspirants marching towards the Jharkhand Legislative Assembly PTI

KEY POINTS

- » Protesters, police clash near Jharkhand Assembly
- » Several protesters, four policemen injured
- » Police use water cannons, tear gas, lathi-charge
- » Protesters breach multiple police barricades

- » Violence erupts near Jagannathpur Temple
- » Protest enters 17th consecutive day
- » Aspirants seek JPSC, JSSC reforms
- » Protesters demand disputed exams scrapped
- » Independent probe into alleged irregularities sought
- » Talks fail to break deadlock



Jharkhand CID arrests ex-JPSC chairperson

RANCHI: Jharkhand CID on Monday arrested former JPSC chairperson L. Khiantge in connection with alleged irregularities in the recruitment examinations, a top official of the state probe agency said.

Khiantge, who was appointed as Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) chairperson in February last year after he retired as the state's chief secretary, tendered his resignation on July 22.

"We have arrested former JPSC chairperson L. Khiantge in connection with irregularities in recruitment examinations," Additional Director General (CID), Manoj Kaushik, said.

Khiantge had been questioned four times since July 28.

The arrest comes a day after all three JPSC members resigned amid massive protests by aspirants over alleged irregularities in recruitment tests conducted by the agency.

With Khiantge's arrest, the number of people arrested by CID in this case has risen to 20.

Continued on P4

Centre offer of Shah's statement on students' stir fails to end deadlock



Cong says 3 demands 'non-negotiable'

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The government's offer to hold a debate on the student protests and police action, with Union Home Minister Amit Shah set to reply, failed to break the over three-week parliamentary deadlock on Monday as the Congress insisted that Prime Minister Narendra Modi respond to a discussion on the alleged donation theft at the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

The Congress maintained that the two issues cannot be separated. Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi reiterated the party's demand for Shah's resignation, while Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju accused the Opposition of avoiding a debate "by giving excuses".

The Congress said its three demands remain unchanged: Shah should clarify whether he ordered police firing on students, Prime Minister Modi should address the alleged Ram temple donation theft, and the Prime Minister should apologise over both issues. The party described the demands

TAKEAWAYS

- » Govt offers full debate on student protests, police action in Lok Sabha
- » Amit Shah to reply if Opposition ensures peaceful discussion
- » Congress insists PM Modi answer Ram temple donation theft issue
- » Rahul Gandhi says student protests, Ram temple issues cannot be separated
- » Rahul demands Amit Shah's resignation over police action
- » Rijiju accuses Congress of avoiding parliamentary debate
- » Monsoon Session remains deadlocked for over three weeks

as "non-negotiable".

The Monsoon Session, which began on July 20, has witnessed repeated disruptions over the student protests linked to the alleged NEET paper leak and the alleged Ram temple donation theft.

With the session scheduled to conclude on Thursday, uncertainty remains over the fate of key

Continued on P4

Banks wrote off Rs 9.95L cr in large corporate loans over 12 years, Parliament told

NEW DELHI: Banks wrote off loans worth Rs 9,95,000 crore extended to large corporates and the services sector over the last 12 financial years, the government informed Parliament on Monday. Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said in a written reply that write-offs peaked at Rs 1,48,753 crore in 2018-19 before falling to Rs 20,485 crore in 2025-26.

Citing Reserve Bank of India data, Chaudhary said outstanding loans to large industries and services rose from Rs 63,19,057 crore in 2024-25 to Rs 69,21,734 crore in 2025-26.

He said a debt write-off is only an accounting procedure and does not amount to a waiver of dues for borrowers, whether farmers or corporates.

Continued on P4

Nine killed as van gets swept away in swollen drain in MP's Rajgarh

RAJGARH (MP): Nine persons, including a girl, were killed after a van carrying 11 passengers got swept away while crossing a swollen nullah (drain) amid heavy rains in Madhya Pradesh's Rajgarh district on Monday, police said.

Two occupants of the van managed to swim to safety following the incident that occurred around 9 am near Sarangpur town when the van driver was attempting to make his way through the Padana bypass culvert, an official said.

Continued on P4

Man posing as IAS officer, Ajit Doval's 'undercover agent' arrested in Bihar

MPOST BUREAU

PATNA: A man accused of posing as an IAS officer, falsely claiming to be an undercover agent of National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and travelling across Bihar in a Tesla displaying a 'Government of India' board has been arrested in Bihar's Khagaria district, police said on Monday. Investigators allege he used the fabricated identity to cheat people in different parts of the state and are now probing the source of his wealth and assets.

The accused, Manish Gupta, was arrested from his residence in Jamalpur under the Gogri police station area after police acted on a tip-off. Khagaria Superintendent of Police Bhanu Pratap Singh said Gupta had projected

Continued on P4

BANKERS' BOOKS EVIDENCE BILL, 2026

Parl passes Bill recognising digital banking records as legal evidence

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Parliament has cleared the Bankers' Books Evidence Bill, 2026, replacing a 135-year-old law with a modern legal framework that recognises electronic, digital and virtual banking records as admissible evidence in courts. The Rajya Sabha passed the Bill by voice vote on Monday after it was approved by the Lok Sabha on August 5. The legislation replaces the Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 1891, enacted during British rule when banking transactions were maintained almost entirely on paper, and aligns the law with India's digital banking ecosystem.

One of the key features of the Bill is that it allows bankers' books to be produced in either physical or electronic form during legal proceedings

The new law provides that bankers' records maintained in electronic or digital form will be admissible, valid and legally enforceable in judicial proceedings, placing them on par with physical records. It introduces a technology-neutral framework for handling banking evidence, reflecting the shift towards digital transactions, mobile

Continued on P4

RS passes Taxation Bill, govt says UPI will remain free for consumers

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Parliament on Monday passed the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, with Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman assuring that the legislation does not impose any tax or transaction charge on Unified Payments Interface (UPI) users.

Continued on P4

AB-PMJAY ISSUED 3.75 CRORE NEW AYUSHMAN CARDS DURING FY26

Govt de-empanels 2,359 hospitals under Ayushman Bharat over scheme violations

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Centre has de-empanelled 2,359 hospitals and suspended another 1,200 from the Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PMJAY) for violating scheme guidelines, Union Health Minister J.P. Nadda informed the Lok Sabha in a written reply on August 7. The government has also registered 29 FIRs against hospitals found violating rules and imposed penalties worth Rs 328.49 crore as part of its action against fraud and unauthorised billing.

The action means that suspended and de-empanelled hospitals cannot offer treatment under AB-PMJAY during the period of exclusion. Beneficiaries have been advised to verify whether a hospital remains empanelled before seeking cashless treatment under the scheme.

CLOSER LOOK

- » Another 1,200 hospitals were suspended under PM-JAY
- » Authorities registered 29 FIRs against errant hospitals
- » Penalties worth Rs 328.49 crore were imposed
- » Suspended hospitals cannot provide PM-JAY cashless treatment

Beneficiaries should verify hospital empanelment before treatment



AI AND MACHINE LEARNING NOW DETECT SUSPICIOUS PM-JAY CLAIMS

To strengthen fraud detection, the National Health Authority (NHA) has introduced artificial intelligence and machine learning tools to identify suspicious claims. Its National Anti-Fraud Unit generates automated alerts within 24 hours of claim submission by detecting unusual patterns such as duplicate claims,

misuse of beneficiary identities, suspicious billing and potentially unnecessary medical procedures. According to the government, the technology-driven system has helped prevent losses of Rs 676.14 crore as of July 31, 2026.

The government said hospitals found violating scheme norms can face financial penalties, sus-

pension, de-empanelment and criminal proceedings.

The crackdown comes as AB-PMJAY continues to expand. During the 2025-26 financial year, 3.75 crore new Ayushman cards were issued and 2.74 crore hospital admissions were authorised under the scheme. The Centre released Rs 8,438.27 crore to state health agencies during the year to support implementation.

Uttar Pradesh recorded the highest number of authorised hospital admissions at 30.6 lakh and received Rs 1,047.53 crore in central assistance.

Ayushman Bharat provides eligible families with cashless health cover of up to Rs 5 lakh annually at empanelled hospitals for more than 1,900 procedures, with states allowed to add more. As of August 8, 2026, the NHA portal listed 38,437 empanelled hospitals, including 20,363 public and 18,074 private hospitals.

At least 111 killed as 7.4 magnitude quake devastates western Colombia



BOGOTA (Colombia): A powerful 7.4 magnitude earthquake struck western Colombia on Monday, killing at least 111 people and causing dozens of buildings to collapse. Authorities said 18 deaths were reported in Pereira and two in Manizales. The quake, centred near San Jose del Palmar in Choco at a depth of 107 km, was felt

as far as Bogota and neighbouring Ecuador. In Cali, Mayor Alejandro Eder said at least 19 collapsed buildings had trapped residents. President Abeloar de la Esmeralda said he was leading the emergency response, telling affected communities, "You are not alone. The state is present and taking action."

See P8

India expands LNG sourcing to 15 countries amid supply concerns

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Centre has expanded the number of countries from which India imports liquefied natural gas (LNG) from six to 15 as it seeks to reduce supply risks arising from geopolitical tensions and maritime transit challenges. The government has also widened its crude oil sourcing network from 27 countries to 41, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said in a written reply to an unstarred question.

Minister of State for Petroleum and Natural Gas Suresh Gopi said the broader sourcing strategy has strengthened India's energy security. "This diversification has reduced dependence on any particular country, region or transit route and enhanced India's ability to manage supply disruptions and market

volatility," he said.

The increase in LNG sourcing was disclosed for the first time in the reply, while the expansion of crude oil imports to 41 countries had been announced earlier following disruptions to energy shipments through West Asia.

The ministry said the government regularly reviews global supply conditions with public sector oil and gas companies and other stakeholders to ensure uninterrupted availability of crude oil, LNG and petroleum products.

The reply also said India plans to expand its strategic petroleum storage capacity. At present, Indian Strategic Petroleum Reserve Limited operates three strategic petroleum reserve facilities in Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka with a combined crude oil storage capacity of 5.33 million metric tonnes.

DRIVER APPREHENDED

7-yr-old boy riding bicycle crushed to death after coming under e-rickshaw

OUR CORRESPONDENT

FARIDABAD: A 7-year-old child riding a bike died after being crushed under an e-rickshaw that overturned on him after a collision in a residential part of Faridabad's Sector 31 area, police said on Monday.

The child was rushed to the hospital but he had already succumbed to his injuries, they said. A CCTV video of the incident surfaced online showing the collision between the bicycle and the e-rickshaw that was loaded with large water bottles, making it heavy.

Police said the e-rickshaw tried to avoid hitting the kid and swerved onto the front side ramp of a house, lost balance and overturned on the child. The driver has been apprehended, they said.

According to police, the incident took place around



5.30 pm on Saturday when Saksham, the son of a techie, was cycling in the street outside his home with a friend. After completing a round, he was heading back towards his house.

At the T-point in front of his home, he turned his bicycle left and collided with an oncoming e-rickshaw. CCTV footage shows the e-rickshaw driver attempting to drive up a

ramp to save the child but the vehicle overturned, trapping the child underneath, police said.

The e-rickshaw was loaded with large water bottles, making it extremely heavy. The weight of the bottles caused the vehicle to lose its balance while ascending the ramp, they said.

Hearing the screams, the child's father, Ajay Rawat, and people nearby immediately rushed to the spot. Within a minute or two, they lifted the overturned e-rickshaw, pulled the child out and rushed him to a hospital where doctors declared him dead, said police.

An FIR was registered on the child's father's complaint, and the e-rickshaw driver was apprehended, police said. The body was handed over to the family after post-mortem. The family has lived in Faridabad for years.

Sanitation worker dies, another critical after entering manhole

OUR CORRESPONDENT

FARIDABAD: A sanitation worker died, while another is in critical condition after both entered a manhole outside a factory in Faridabad Sector-25, police said on Monday.

According to the police, Aslam and Bunty, residents of the Ashiana flats in Sector 56, work as sewer cleaners.

On Monday, the factory owner called the duo to clean the manhole, following which they arrived at 10 am.

Police citing eyewitnesses said the two descended into the manhole without any safety gear. They soon began to suffocate and cried out for help, prompting the bystanders to

help them out.

Police said they arrived at the scene after being informed of the incident and helped rescue Aslam and Bunty.

While Aslam (34) died on the spot, Bunty (37) was admitted to a private hospital in critical condition, police said.

Aslam's family members have filed a complaint, blaming the factory owner's negligence for his death. "We have received a complaint from relatives of the deceased. A case will be registered against the factory owner following an investigation. We have sent the body to a mortuary for a post-mortem examination", Inspector Kewal Singh, SHO of Sector-58 police station, said.

Ggm woman arrested for assaulting domestic help

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: A woman, who was caught on camera allegedly assaulting her domestic help inside a luxury apartment here, was arrested by Gurugram Police on Monday and later released on police bail after she agreed to join the investigation, officials said.

An FIR was registered against the woman based on a nearly 90-second video clip recorded by a neighbour through a kitchen window, they said.

The 52-year-old woman, a resident of The Camellias Apartment on Golf Course Road in Sector 42, has been booked under Section 115 (voluntarily causing hurt) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), police said.

A senior police officer said the video, recorded from another apartment through a kitchen window, shows the woman repeatedly slapping the domestic help inside the kitchen and pulling her hair.

According to an official



statement, the police team of Sushant Lok police station took suo motu cognisance of the video that had gone viral on social media platform X and initiated an inquiry.

During the inquiry, police found that the incident took place on July 24 at The Camellias Apartment in Sector 42, following which a case was registered at Sushant Lok police station under relevant sections, the statement said.

The police said the accused woman joined the investigation.

"During the preliminary investigation, it was revealed that the woman whom the accused had assaulted was her domestic help, who had

left the job on July 27. The accused woman had assaulted the domestic help following an argument regarding work. Further action in the case will be taken as per rules. The case is under investigation," a Gurugram Police spokesperson said.

According to police sources, the domestic help, a native of Nepal, had been working at the accused woman's home for around two years.

A relative of the domestic help had earlier said that she had not lodged any complaint with the Gurugram Police and did not hold any grievance against her employer.

The domestic help seen in the video has since returned to her hometown and, in a written statement, requested that the video be removed from social media platforms, police sources said.

The police, however, took suo motu cognisance of the viral video and initiated action.

Police said the circumstances surrounding the incident and the video are being investigated.

News at a glance

MAN FATALLY STABBED OVER RS 700 LOAN DISPUTE: COPS

NEW DELHI: A 30-year-old man was stabbed to death in Rohini after allegedly intervening when a man confronted his brother over a Rs 700 loan, police said. Three men, including an accused with 10 previous theft cases, were arrested. The victim, Mukesh Yadav, succumbed to his injuries at AIIMS early Monday.

SOUTH DELHI: 2 HELD FOR THEFT OF SNAKE IDOL FROM TEMPLE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police arrested two men and recovered 800 grams of melted silver allegedly belonging to a stolen temple idol in Greater Kailash-I, an officer said. Police said Mohit Sharma, 40, stole a snake idol from the Sanatan Dharma Satsang Sabha Temple, melted it and sold the silver to jeweller Bharat Gandhi, 35, in Karol Bagh. Gandhi was arrested for allegedly receiving stolen property. Police also recovered Rs 1.10 lakh, suspected to be sale proceeds, and the car used in the crime. An e-FIR was registered on August 6, and CCTV footage helped trace the accused. Neither had previous criminal involvement, police said.

POLICE NAB 5, SEIZE 45 REELS OF BANNED CHINESE MANJHA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police arrested five people in separate cases for allegedly possessing and selling banned Chinese manjha in central Delhi. Police recovered 45 reels and spools of the manjha. Two accused were caught near Meena Bazar and Hauz Qazi, while others were apprehended in Himmatgarh, Ajmeri Gate and Takiya Kale Khan. Police are tracing the supply chain.

Police nab 52 people under ‘Op Shastra’ ahead of I-Day

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has apprehended 52 people in a major crackdown under Operation Shastra ahead of Independence Day, registering 41 cases and recovering 15 illegal firearms, 26 live cartridges and nine knives, in addition to narcotics and illicit liquor, an official said on Monday.

Police said the operation was launched to target criminals involved in street crime, illegal arms business and other unlawful activities and to strengthen preventive security ahead of August 15.

The arms crackdown covered several police station areas, including Aman Vihar, Prem Nagar, Begumpur, Kanjhawala, Prashant Vihar, Budh Vihar, K N Katju Marg, South Rohini, Vijay Vihar and North

The arms crackdown covered several PS areas, including Aman Vihar, Prem Nagar, Begumpur, Budh Vihar

Rohini. "Police recovered country-made pistols and cartridges from several accused, while knives were seized in several cases. In one case, a stolen scooter and a mobile phone were also recovered," a senior police officer said.

Police said they also seized a large quantity of illicit liquor and registered cases under the Excise Act, Gambling Act and NDPS Act. Further investigation and preventive action are underway.

Police identified one of the accused from whom the fire-

arms were recovered as Rahul Sehrawat, an active member of the Neeraj Bawaniya and Naveen Bali gangs.

Several other accused apprehended during the drive also had criminal antecedents, including history-sheeters, bad characters and a proclaimed offender. The KN Katju Marg unit apprehended Vipin, also known as Lala or Pankaj.

He allegedly has 26 previous cases, including four under the Arms Act, nine involving snatching, one robbery, 11 theft cases and one under the Excise Act, police said.

Police said he is a bad character and a proclaimed offender in a Shahbad Dairy case.

Another accused, Manish Saini alias Lallu, allegedly has 10 cases, including three under the Arms Act, four robbery cases and three theft cases.

Accountant arrested for ₹1.96 crore fraud

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 32-year-old accountant accused of siphoning nearly Rs 1.96 crore from his employer has been arrested by Delhi Police after evading arrest for almost three years, officials said.

The accused, Triloki Sharma, a resident of Inderpuri, was arrested from the Samba Industrial Area in Jammu and Kashmir on August 4 with the help of local police.

Police said the case was registered at Samaypur Badli

police station on August 17, 2023, after the owner of a private company alleged that Sharma had transferred company funds to his own account and cheated him.

A special team conducted financial analysis and technical surveillance to trace Sharma. Police said he allegedly transferred part of the money to dozens of bank accounts in Samba.

He also allegedly admitted to gambling and betting on cricket matches. The money trail is being investigated.

Delhi Metro achieves 99.95% punctuality

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Defying the challenges that typically accompany an expanding rail network, the Delhi Metro has achieved an exceptional 99.95 per cent train punctuality in 2026 so far, cementing its place among the world's most reliable metro systems. The achievement comes as the network continues to witness unprecedented passenger growth, with daily ridership rising from just 82,000 passengers in its first year of operations to a record single-day patronage of over 81 lakh passenger journeys on



August 8, 2025.

According to the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), the system has outperformed several of the world's leading metro networks, including those in Hong Kong, Paris

and New York, in punctuality and reliability. Unlike many global systems that classify delays only after several minutes, the Delhi Metro records a delay if a train reaches its destination station more than 59 seconds behind schedule.

DMRC said train punctuality improved from 98.27 per cent in 2003 to 99.64 per cent in 2005, and has consistently remained above 99.9 per cent over the years.

The corporation has also achieved a Mean Distance Between Failures (MDBF) of 2.72 million car-kilometres, placing it among the top

five metro systems globally in reliability under the Community of Metros (COMET) benchmarking.

The network has also significantly increased operational efficiency, reducing train headway from seven minutes in its early years to 2 minutes and 18 seconds on its busiest corridors.

Delhi Metro has expanded from an 8.4-km corridor with six stations in 2002 to a 416.5-km network spanning 303 stations across 12 lines. Daily ridership averages 64.06 lakh passenger journeys, while nearly 29 per cent operates driverlessly.

DELHI TO PREPARE 30-YEAR ROADMAP FOR WATER INFRA Centre grants approval for DJB’s water supply improvement project: Minister

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push to overhaul Delhi's ageing water infrastructure, the Centre has granted in-principle approval to a Rs.2,574-crore Asian Development Bank (ADB)-assisted Wazirabad Water Supply Improvement Project, while the Delhi government has also initiated the process to prepare a comprehensive 30-year Water Master Plan for the capital. The project, which had remained stalled since it was first conceptualised in 2013, is expected to improve water supply for millions of residents across North and North-West Delhi through new pipelines, digital monitoring systems and a long-term infrastructure roadmap.

The Screening Committee of the Department of Economic Affairs (DEA) has cleared the project, paving the way for implementation. Covering the entire water supply chain—from treatment and transmis-



sion to distribution networks and household connections, the initiative seeks to reduce water losses, improve efficiency and strengthen Delhi's overall water infrastructure.

Delhi Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said the project is designed to prepare the capital's water network for future demand. "For the people of Delhi, water is a daily necessity. Our responsibility is to make sure that the infrastructure behind every tap is strong, modern and reliable. The Wazirabad project is a major step in that direction. We are not planning only for today; we are building a water system that

can serve Delhi for decades," he said.

The project includes replacement of old and damaged pipelines, installation of new transmission and distribution lines, upgrading of the Wazirabad Water Treatment Plant, reservoirs and pumping stations, and improvement of household water connections. It also aims to reduce Non-Revenue Water (NRW), water lost due to leakages, physical losses and unauthorised consumption.

A major feature of the project is the creation of eight interconnected Command Centres covering Wazirabad, Chandrawal, West, South-West, East, North-East, North-West and South Delhi. Using SCADA-based digital monitoring, officials will be able to track water flow, pressure, reservoir levels and pumping operations in real time. "The eight Command Centres will make Delhi's water network one connected

system.... Technology must ultimately translate into better service for citizens," the minister said.

The Wazirabad command area includes Burari, Model Town, Jahangirpuri, Punjabi Bagh, Pitampura, Shakur Basti, Peeragarhi, Sanjay Gandhi Transport Nagar, Avantika and adjoining residential and institutional areas, meaning the project is expected to strengthen water infrastructure for millions of people across North and North-West Delhi.

The Delhi Jal Board has also placed proposals for a Rs.43.77-crore Project Management Consultancy and an Rs.88.63-crore consultancy to prepare a 30-year Water Master Plan for Delhi. "Delhi cannot plan its water infrastructure one project at a time. We need a clear roadmap for the next 30 years," Singh said, adding that the government aims to build "a modern and connected water system for the whole of Delhi."

Kanwar rush, rainfall lead to traffic congestion at several city stretches

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Long lines of cars, groups of Kanwariyas on motorcycles and on foot, crowded markets and roadside Kanwar camps marked several parts of Delhi on Monday as the annual pilgrimage entered its penultimate day.

At several places, commuters found themselves moving slowly through stretches already busy with regular traffic, while groups of pilgrims made their way towards their destinations carrying Kanwars – decorated bamboo poles with containers of Ganga water suspended from them.

Residents reported long queues on Radhakrishnan Marg and Abai Marg and on the stretch between LSR College and Nehru Place. Traffic was also slow near the Savitri flyover towards Chirag Delhi, while a gathering at a Kanwar camp near Shri Shiv Hanuman Mandir in Sector 2, Rohini, added to congestion in the area.

The roads around some of the camps had a different scene,



with groups of devotees gathered under temporary shelters, saffron flags bearing images of Hindu deities fluttering above them and Kanwariyas stopping along the route before continuing their journey.

Several pilgrims were seen travelling on motorcycles or walking in groups, carrying their kanwars on their shoulders. Their movement, along with the gatherings around camps and increased pedestrian activity in markets, affected the flow of regular traffic at several locations.

In Greater Kailash, traffic near the Archana Complex

red light was affected by ongoing road-divider construction, residents said. Near the Main Uttam Nagar red light, commuters complained that e-rickshaws, rehri-patri vendors and flower shops had occupied portions of the road.

Encroachments narrowed the carriageway, restricting vehicle movement and making it difficult for emergency vehicles to pass. Traffic was slow near the Delhi-Meerut Expressway around Patparganj amid heavy rain. A commuter video showed a car travelling on the wrong side, raising safety concerns.

PEDALLING TOWARDS SELF-RELIANCE

CM distributes bicycles to 200 girl students under ‘Vidya Vahini’

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday distributed bicycles to 200 Class 9 girl students under the Vidya Vahini Yojana, saying the initiative is aimed at making education more accessible and ensuring that transportation challenges do not force girls to discontinue their studies. The event was held at the Delhi Assembly premises, where students from Zone 7 of the North district received bicycles.

The Delhi government plans to distribute bicycles to around 1.40 lakh Class 9 girl students across the city during the current academic year under the scheme. The initiative seeks to ease commuting to schools, reduce travel time and promote confidence and self-reliance among girl students.

Interacting with the beneficiaries, Gupta said a bicycle is more than just



a mode of transport. “A bicycle is not merely a means of transport but also a way to support girls’ education and help them pursue their dreams,” she said, adding that the government is committed to ensuring that distance from school or transport-related difficulties do not become obstacles in any girl’s education.

Highlighting the broader

objective of the scheme, the Chief Minister said the government is working to make education more accessible and convenient for girls by providing better facilities and equal opportunities.

“Investment in girls’ education is an investment in the bright future of society,” she said, urging students to use the bicycles to pursue their

CLOSER LOOK

» ‘A bicycle is not merely a means of transport but also a way to support girls’ education and help them pursue their dreams,’ she said

» She stressed that the government is committed to ensuring that distance from school or transport-related difficulties do not become obstacles in any girl’s education journey

education with determination, set ambitious goals and move ahead with confidence.

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood described the programme as part of a larger transformation of the capital’s education system. “Under the visionary leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta Ji, Delhi’s school education is moving towards historic change,”

he said.

Sood added that distributing bicycles is not merely about providing transport but also about empowering girls to become self-reliant, overcome barriers and continue their education without interruption.

He said the government remains committed to ensuring that no girl student in Delhi is left behind because of mobility or access-related challenges. Students who received the bicycles expressed enthusiasm, saying the initiative would make daily travel to school easier, save commuting time and enable them to focus more on their studies with greater confidence.

The government said the scheme forms part of its broader efforts to improve educational access and create a supportive learning environment for girls across the national capital.

Assembly tables CAG reports and introduces three key Bills

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Assembly on Monday witnessed a busy legislative agenda with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta tabling two Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) reports highlighting the capital’s fiscal and economic performance, while the government introduced three significant Bills aimed at reforming public service delivery, slum rehabilitation and higher education. Ministers also defended the BJP government’s flagship Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, saying it reflected the government’s commitment to women’s economic empowerment.



legal right to receive notified government services within a stipulated timeframe.

The proposed law provides for online applications, a unique application number for tracking every request, automatic escalation of delayed cases and a two-tier grievance redressal mechanism. It also fixes accountability for officials who delay services without valid reasons or wrongly reject applications. Such officials can be fined Rs.250 per day, up to a maximum of Rs.5,000, with the amount recoverable from their salaries after due process.

The Bill also proposes the establishment of a Delhi Right to Service Commission, empowered to inspect government offices, summon officials, examine records and recommend disciplinary action. It will apply to services provided by the Delhi government, MCD, NDMC, Delhi Cantonment Board, Delhi Jal Board, Delhi Development Authority (DDA) and other notified bodies.

Pankaj Singh said the government aimed to build “a simple and transparent system in which citizens do not have to make repeated visits to government offices.” He added that “through time-bound service delivery, online application and tracking, auto-escalation, and clear accountability of officials, the Bill will strengthen citizens’ rights and reinforce a transparent, accountable and citizen-centric system of governance.”

Training and Technical Education Minister Ashish Sood introduced the Delhi Private Universities Bill, 2026, which seeks to establish a legal framework for setting up and regulating private universities in the national capital.

The House also took up the DUSIB Amendment Bill, 2026, proposing to shift the jhuggi jhopri basti recognition cut-off from January 1, 2006 to January 1, 2025, enabling more clusters to qualify for rehabilitation.

Most grants spent on day-to-day expenditure

A separate CAG report on grants-in-aid found that only 6 to 27 per cent of financial assistance extended to local bodies and institutions between 2015-16 and 2024-25 was meant for creation of capital assets, while 73 to 94 per cent was spent on routine expenditure.

Total assistance stood at Rs.16,449 crore in 2024-25, a decline of 3.5 per cent over the previous year. Municipal corporations remained the biggest beneficiaries, receiving Rs.9,282 crore, followed by Delhi Transport Corporation (Rs.2,620 crore), Delhi Jal Board (Rs.633 crore) and Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board (Rs.162 crore). Grants earmarked for capital asset creation fell to Rs.1,110 crore, accounting for only 6.75 per cent of the total assistance during the year.

Three key Bills introduced

The Assembly also saw the introduction of three important Bills.

IT Minister Pankaj Singh introduced the Delhi (Right of Citizens to Time Bound and Ease of Delivery of Services) Bill, 2026, which seeks to replace the 2011 legislation and provide citizens with a

CAG flags slower growth, declining capital spending

The CAG’s report on the finances of the Government of NCT of Delhi for 2024-25 showed that Delhi’s Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) grew by 9.17 per cent to Rs.12.15 lakh crore, accounting for 3.67 per cent of India’s GDP.

However, it noted that Delhi’s long-term economic growth had lagged behind the national average. The per capita GSDP registered a compound annual growth rate of 6.39 per cent between 2015 and 2025, compared to 8.14 per cent for the country’s per capita GDP.

“This reflects the slightly slower economic growth of the Delhi government compared to the rest of the country,” the report observed, noting that Delhi’s per capita GSDP, which was 177.07 per cent higher than the national average in 2015-16, narrowed to 135.34 per cent by 2024-25.

The report said revenue receipts increased by 9.57 per cent, mainly due to higher GST collections, while non-tax revenue fell by 11.04 per cent and grants from the Centre also declined. Revenue expenditure constituted 88.38 per cent of total expenditure, with subsidies increasing by Rs.3,222

Labourer dies after being run over by crane

NEW DELHI: A 31-year-old labourer was killed after allegedly being run over by a crane in Delhi’s Mayapuri area on Sunday, police said. The victim, Rahul, a Mayapuri resident, was critically injured and died before he could be taken to hospital.

Police registered an FIR under Sections 281 and 106(1) of the BNS and seized the crane. Its operator, Dharam Dev, 49, was arrested. Police said further investigation is underway to establish the sequence of events leading to the accident. **MP05T**

₹40-cr multilevel parking facility set to open at Bhikaji Cama Place

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Parking congestion at Bhikaji Cama Place District Centre is likely to ease next month, with the Delhi Development Authority’s (DDA) Multilevel Car Parking (MLCP) facility expected to be completed by then.

The ₹40.01-crore facility will accommodate 645 vehicles, including 452 cars and 193 two-wheelers. Of the car spaces, 20 will be reserved for persons with disabilities. The facility will also have eight parking spaces, four lifts and a waiting room for visitors and

The MLCP will also feature parking guidance systems, EV charging facilities...

drivers. It will provide separate toilets for women, men and persons with disabilities, along with drinking water and barrier-free access. Two dedicated lifts will connect the parking facility directly to the raised plaza of Bhikaji Cama Place District Centre, providing convenient access to offices located there.

Spread across a basement,

ground floor, first floor, second floor and terrace level, the facility has a total covered area of 19,354 square metres. It is being constructed as a conventional parking facility with an RCC-framed structure designed to withstand seismic forces.

The MLCP will feature parking guidance systems, EV charging facilities, CCTV surveillance, firefighting systems and two rainwater harvesting units. The facility is aimed at providing safer, organised and accessible parking while easing congestion in the busy commercial hub.

BJP takes out Tiranga Yatra through Old Delhi

NEW DELHI: As part of the week-long celebrations leading up to India’s 80th Independence Day, the Delhi unit of the Bharatiya Janata Party on Monday organised a grand Tiranga Yatra through the streets of Old Delhi, led by Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra. The march began at Chandni Chowk Town Hall and concluded at Hauz Qazi, with thousands of party workers, school students and local residents participating.

The route was decorated with tricolour flags and ceremonial arches, while several traders’ and civic organisations welcomed the participants at different points along the



procession. Chandni Chowk MP Praveen Khandelwal also joined the march.

Addressing participants, Malhotra said Old Delhi holds a special place in the country’s freedom movement. “The Red Fort in Old Delhi is not merely made of bricks and stones; it is from here that the Prime

Minister addresses the nation every August 15. The call for independence was announced from here, and every inch of Old Delhi is steeped in sacrifice and self-respect,” he said.

Highlighting the area’s communal harmony, he added, “The identity of Old Delhi is its Ganga-Jamuni Tehzeeb. In Old Delhi, the sound of temple bells and the azaan from mosques resonate together... this unity represents the true spirit of our national Tricolour.” He urged people to strengthen the ‘Har Ghar Tiranga’ campaign and uphold the honour of the national flag.

Khandelwal said the Tricolour symbolises the nation’s

pride and the sacrifices of freedom fighters. “The Tricolour is a symbol of our honour, pride and glory, and Independence Day reminds us of the martyrs who sacrificed everything for the nation,” he said, appealing to citizens to make the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign a success before August 15 and promote unity and brotherhood.

Several BJP leaders, municipal councillors and district office-bearers also participated in the yatra, which was coordinated by Chandni Chowk district president Arvind Garg. The event formed part of the party’s outreach programmes ahead of Independence Day celebrations. **MP05T**

Speaker seeks MCD action report on stray cattle, garbage

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Monday referred garbage management and stray cattle on city roads to the Assembly’s Special Committee on the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), directing the civic body to submit detailed Action Taken Reports.

The move followed concerns raised by MLAs Anil Goyal and Harish Khurana over garbage-prone areas, open dustbins, inadequate waste collection and cattle roaming on roads.

Gupta directed the MCD Commissioner to appear before the committee and explain corrective measures, including scrutiny of underperforming waste collection concessionaires and steps to strengthen sanitation and waste collection across the city.

Calling the stray cattle issue “alarming”, Gupta sought details on Delhi’s gaushalas, their capacity, arrangements for rescued cattle, the impounding process and action against those abandoning cattle on public roads. He also stressed the need for prompt measures to protect public safety and animal welfare.

MUSICAL FOUNTAINS AND GREENERY PLANNED

MCD begins ₹9.7-cr Naini Lake rejuvenation project

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has undertaken a ₹9.73-crore project to rejuvenate and beautify Naini Lake in Model Town under the Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (AMRUT) 2.0 scheme.

The development work was inaugurated on Sunday in the presence of Cabinet Minister Kapil Mishra, MLA Ashok Goyal, Area Councillor Vikesh Sethi and Deputy Commissioner Mohit Bansal.

The project, being implemented in Ward No. 68 of the Keshav Puram Zone, is aimed at improving the lake’s environmental and recreational value while promoting the sustainable reuse of treated wastewater.

As part of the project, treated sewage treatment plant (STP) water from the Coronation Pillar STP will be conveyed to Naini Lake. The excess treated water will subsequently be used for irrigation of nearby municipal parks, according to the MCD.

The civic body said the initiative would help improve water management in the area by promoting the reuse



“Planned works include installation of decorative lighting, horticultural dev and remodelling of peripheral RCC drain...”

of treated wastewater for non-potable purposes.

The planned works include the installation of decorative lighting, horticultural development and remodelling of the peripheral reinforced cement concrete (RCC) drain around the lake. Two musical fountains will also be installed as part of the beautification measures.

In addition, the existing grill and boundary of the lake will be repaired. The MCD said the interventions were intended to improve the overall appearance and functionality of the lake and create a more attractive public space

for residents. The rejuvenation of Naini Lake is also expected to strengthen its role as a recreational and environmental asset in the Model Town area. The project is being undertaken at a contractual cost of ₹9.73 crore.

According to the civic body, the work is scheduled to be completed by July 2027.

The project comes as the MCD undertakes infrastructure and environmental improvement works under AMRUT 2.0, which focuses on improving urban water management and related civic amenities.

DELHI POLICE
SHANTI SEWA NYAYA

**CELEBRATE FREEDOM
PROTECT DELHI'S SKIES**

**FLYING DRONES AND UNMANNED
AERIAL VEHICLES IN THE JURISDICTION
OF THE NCT OF DELHI IS**

**PROHIBITED
UPTO 16.08.2026**

**Para-gliders | Para-motors | Hang-gliders | UAVs / UASs | Microlight
aircraft | Remotely piloted aircraft | Hot air balloons | Small-sized
powered aircraft | Quadcopters | Para-jumping from aircraft**

**To Report these
Prohibited
Activities**

**Any Violation of the directive is
punishable offence under Section 223
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FOR IMMEDIATE POLICE HELP CALL 112 **TO SHARE ANTI TERRORIST ACTIVITIES, CALL 14547**

DEVOTION UNDER THREAT

UP: 5 killed, 41 injured in separate road accidents involving devotees, Kanwars

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: Five devotees were killed and a total of 41 people injured in separate road accidents involving pilgrims and Kanwariyas in Uttar Pradesh on Monday, police said.

The accidents were reported from Kaushambi, where one person was killed and 30 were injured; Barabanki, where two devotees were killed and one was injured; Kasganj, where two Kanwariyas were killed and one was injured; Pratapgarh, where six Kanwariyas were injured; and Maharajganj, where three devotees were injured, police said.

The highest number of casualties was reported from Kaushambi, where a pilgrim was killed and 30 others, including the driver, were injured after a pickup vehicle carrying 36 devotees overturned on National Highway-19.

The accident occurred near Kasia village when the pilgrims



A group of Kanwariyas (devotees of Lord Shiva) travel atop a decorated open-top truck along a highway, in New Delhi, Monday

PTI

Highlights

» The highest number of casualties was reported from Kaushambi, where a pilgrim was killed and 30 others

» In Kasganj, two Kanwariyas were killed and another seriously injured when their motorcycle collided with a car

from Nizampur Puraini were travelling to Maa Sheetla Dham in Kada for a holy dip and darshan, police said.

Superintendent of Police Satyanarayan Prajapat said the driver was attempting to overtake a bus when he lost control

of the overloaded vehicle that was travelling at high speed and it overturned. Ram Sharan (18), a resident of Nizampur Puraini, died on the spot. Six seriously-injured pilgrims were referred to the SRN Hospital in Prayagraj. District Magistrate Amit

Pal, Prajapat and Chief Medical Officer Sanjay Prasad visited the district hospital.

In Barabanki, two devotees were killed and another was seriously injured after a tractor-trolley collided with their motorcycle near Dadanpur village on Sunday night. The three victims -- Shaktiman Joshi (19), Shailendra alias Hemal Joshi (22) and Sachin Joshi (21) -- were travelling to the Lodheswar Mahadeva temple to offer water on the second Monday of Shravan.

In Kasganj, two Kanwariyas were killed and another was seriously injured when their motorcycle collided with a car near the Kali River bridge, Superintendent of Police O P Singh said. The three were part of a group of around 30 Kanwariyas from Agra travelling to Soron to collect Gangajal.

Doctors declared Harigovind (26) and Rahul (18) dead, while Vivek was referred to a higher medical centre in Agra.

In Pratapgarh, six Kanwariyas were seriously injured after their pickup vehicle overturned near the Natraj petrol pump in Dabhiar under Lalganj Kotwali, police said. Additional Superintendent of Police (West) Brijnandan Rai said the Kanwariyas were returning after offering Ganga water at Ghuisarnath Dham. The injured were identified as Shani Bharti (20), Himanshu (22), Shivam (19), Nirmala Sahu (18), Pawan (26) and Anil (26).

Bharti, Himanshu and Shivam were referred to a medical college.

In Maharajganj, three devotees were injured after a tractor-trolley carrying around 35 people fell into a roadside canal near Padri Kala village. The devotees from Pipariya Guru Govind Rai village were returning from the Itahiya Shiva temple after offering prayers on the second Monday of Shravan when the driver lost control of the vehicle, police said.

Heavy rains lash various districts in Madhya Pradesh; 98 rescued

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BHOPAL: Several districts in Madhya Pradesh were battered by heavy rains on Monday, sending rivers into spate and necessitating rescue of 98 people by the state disaster emergency response force and Home Guards from waterlogged areas, officials said.

In a rain-related incident, nine people, including a girl, were killed after a van carrying 11 passengers was swept away while crossing a swollen nullah (drain) in Raigarh district on Monday, police said.

The State Disaster Emergency Response Force (SDERF) Headquarters in Bhopal is continuously monitoring the situation in all sensitive and flooded districts.

Quick Response Teams (QRT), disaster relief vehicles, boats and modern equipment are kept ready at all district headquarters to tackle any emergency, officials said.

Director General of Home Guards, Civil Defence and Disaster Management Pragya Richa Srivastava said emer-



A police vehicle is seen partially submerged in water on a flooded street following heavy rainfall, in Raigarh district, Monday

PTI

gency reports of waterlogging and civilians trapped in floods were received from several districts on Monday.

Responding promptly, regional teams launched rescue operations at various locations, leading to the rescue of 98 civilians, seven cattle, and four domestic animals, she said.

A serious disaster situation arose due to the sudden rise in the water level of a drain in Jamni village in Sehore district, where a 23-year-old pregnant woman, Geeta Rajput, and

three other family members were trapped in their home due to a swollen drain, Srivastava said.

She said a team of SDERF and Home Guards immediately arrived at the scene and, using a rubber boat, carefully rescued the pregnant woman and three family members, and transported them to an ambulance.

In the Ahmedpur police station area of Sehore, around 60 km from the headquarters, four citizens trapped in the flooded area were safely rescued by the SDERF team.

From Page 1

Protesters, police claim injuries

The protesters said the government had agreed to cancel only three of the 13 exams they wanted scrapped.

The agitators are demanding comprehensive reforms in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC).

They are also seeking cancellation of several recruitment tests, including the 14th Jharkhand PSC Civil Services Examination, and an independent probe into the alleged irregularities, either by the CBI or by a panel of retired high court judges from outside the state.

The march, which coincided with the 51st birthday of Chief Minister Hemant Soren, began from outside the old Assembly building around 10.30 am as the protest over the recruitment exam irregularities entered the 17th day.

JLKM leader Devendra Nath Mahto, who has been on a fast for nine days over the issue, joined the march in an ambulance. He was seen carrying a portrait of former chief minister Shibui Soren.

Objecting to the installation of barbed-wire barricades along the route of the Assembly march, Mahto said anger was brewing among students over the injustices done to them. "The government is hell-bent on suppressing our voice. We will not hold any talks now," he said.

As police used water cannons when the march reached Jagannathpur Temple, the demonstrators broke into dance, waving the national flag. But the situation soon escalated when the protesters attempted to march forward, prompting the police to baton charge.

Failing to restrain the gathering, the police fired several rounds of tear gas shells when the protesters were about 200 meters away from the Assembly.

The JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch, which is spearheading the agitation, said it has deployed around 500 volunteers to prevent anti-social elements from joining the march.

State minister Sudivya Kumar claimed that the BJP had "hijacked" the protest for its political ambition. Talking to reporters outside the Assembly, he said it was unfortunate that the job aspirants were agitating despite the government fulfilling 95 per cent of their demands.

Earlier, replying to a query on the protests in the Assembly, Kumar alleged the agitation has shifted from being a students' movement to one dominated by "BJP's evil mentality and political designs".

While the protesters alleged that several of them, including women, were injured in the police action, Ranchi City SP Paras Rana said four policemen suffered injuries during stone pelting by the demonstrators.

Student leader Ravindar Paswan alleged that protesters were chased for a kilometre, and beaten by police after he was separated from the march.

"Thousands of students who arrived here on our call were chased and brutally beaten by the police for about one kilometre. This is not democracy. Hemant Soren should not become a dictator. Many of our friends, the agitating students, suffered injuries due to the lathi-charge," Paswan asserted.

Another protester, Jyoti Mahto, said the agitators would continue their sit-in until their demands were met.

JLKM MLA Jairam Mahto, who joined the agitation a day after holding a fast over the issue, questioned the police

action.

Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha state president Shashank Raj described the police action as a "black day for democracy", and alleged that several protesters were injured. He urged the chief minister not to be "insensitive" towards the students' demands.

The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) also condemned the lathi-charge, use of water cannons and tear gas, alleging that students with legitimate demands were met with police force instead of dialogue. It also announced a fresh march to the Vidhan Sabha on August 11.

More than 1,500 personnel from the Rapid Action Force, Indian Reserve Battalion, district police and quick response teams were deployed along the nearly four-kilometre route, officials said. Prohibitory orders were also imposed in the area.

(WITH AGENCY INPUTS)

Jharkhand CID

He had resigned as JPSC chairperson a day before the CID searched multiple locations, including his official residence, in connection with the alleged irregularities.

Khiangte, however, said he "voluntarily chose to resign" to ensure an impartial investigation into the matter.

MPPOST

Centre offer of Shah's statement

legislation, including the Women's Reservation Amendment Bill, which lapsed in the previous session, and the Foreign Contributions (Regulation) Amendment Bill.

Of the nine Bills passed by the Lok Sabha so far, only two were debated, while the remaining legislation was cleared amid Opposition protests.

Amid the impasse, Rijiju announced that the government was ready for a full-fledged discussion on the student protests and police action, with Shah replying on behalf of the government, provided the Opposition allowed the debate to proceed without disruptions.

He said the Congress and Rahul Gandhi had been demanding a statement from Shah since the beginning of the session and urged the Opposition not to walk out during the Home Minister's reply.

Rijiju's announcement followed a meeting of the Lok Sabha Business Advisory Committee, which discussed the House agenda for the remaining three days of the session.

Although Shah has not participated in proceedings during the current session, he has been regularly visiting the Parliament House complex.

"We have made it clear to the Business Advisory Committee that the government is ready for a full-fledged discussion on the student and youth agitations taking place in different parts of the country and the police action. The Home Minister will give a point-by-point reply on behalf of the government," Rijiju told reporters.

He added that the Opposition must assure the government that it would participate peacefully and not disrupt proceedings.

Asked whether the alleged Ram temple donation theft would also be discussed in Parliament, Rijiju said the Uttar Pradesh government had already constituted a Special Investigation Team and other action was underway at the state level.

The Congress dismissed Rijiju's statement as an attempt to "mislead" the Opposition and accused the government of evading responsibility.

Rahul Gandhi said the issue was

never about Shah making a general statement in Parliament.

"The question is who authorised the shooting of our children in Delhi. He is the Home Minister. Pellet guns were fired," Gandhi said, demanding that Shah clarify whether he ordered the police action.

"If Shah ordered it, he is culpable. If he did not know, he is incompetent," Gandhi said, adding that "either way Shah should go". He also said Prime Minister Modi should apologise for the police action against students during the Jantar Mantar protest.

Addressing a press conference with Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Gandhi said the third issue was the alleged donation theft at the Ram temple.

Kharge said the Opposition had sought a discussion on both issues but the government remained silent for over two weeks, indicating that it did not want a debate.

"Under Modi ji's trusted trustees, theft of donations took place. We wanted the guilty punished and the Prime Minister to make a statement, but the government did not pay heed," he said.

Kharge also said Modi should apologise because "lakhs of people have faith in the Ram temple".

"These three issues are non-negotiable. We stand firm on them and the government must respond," he said.

The student protests, led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) at Jantar Mantar, began on June 20 and ended after 36 days on July 25 following the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Education Minister and the government's acceptance of the protesters' other demands.

Responding to the Congress' stand, Rijiju said the debate would reveal "who is running away from discussion".

"When the Home Minister is ready, Rahul Gandhi is running away. You level allegations and then run away. That is not good for democracy. You have to face the debate. I want to tell Rahul Gandhi not to run away by giving excuses," he said.

Banks wrote

Referring to the RBI's Resolution of Stressed Assets Directions, 2025, he said write-offs are undertaken mainly for technical or prudential reasons to adjust bank balance sheets. Borrowers remain legally liable to repay their loans, while banks continue recovery proceedings.

The minister added that the RBI's Master Direction on Resolution of Stressed Assets, issued on November 28, 2025 and updated on July 1, 2026, allows lenders to restructure stressed loans under board-approved policies and regulatory norms.

In separate replies, Chaudhary said the Centre remained committed to fiscal discipline alongside economic growth. The fiscal deficit declined from 9.2 per cent of GDP in 2020-21 to 4.4 per cent in 2025-26, while outstanding liabilities fell from 61.5 per cent to 58.2 per cent of GDP. Capital expenditure increased from Rs 4.3 lakh crore to Rs 10.7 lakh crore during the same period.

He said real private final consumption expenditure growth accelerated to 7.7 per cent in 2025-26 from 5.8 per cent a year earlier, retail inflation averaged 2.1 per cent, and the unemployment rate fell to 3.1 per cent in 2025 from 6 per cent in 2017-18.

The minister also said 5,85,751 digital payment frauds involving Rs 3,590.70 crore were detected over the last five financial years. He said the government, the RBI and NPCI have strengthened cybersecurity, fraud detection, consumer awareness and complaint redressal.

On the external sector, Chaudhary

said India's external debt stood at USD 762.8 billion at the end of March 2026.

The external debt-to-GDP ratio was 20.8 per cent, foreign exchange reserves equalled 90.6 per cent of total external debt, short-term debt accounted for 19.6 per cent of the total, and the debt service ratio improved to 5.8 per cent from 6.6 per cent a year earlier. He said these indicators showed India's external debt remained sustainable and that the government was reducing import dependence by strengthening domestic manufacturing, diversifying import sources and investing in renewable energy and other emerging sectors.

MPPOST

Parl passes Bill

banking, online payments and fintech services across the country.

The legislation comes at a time when India's financial sector has expanded far beyond conventional banks. Along with scheduled banks, the ecosystem now includes non-banking financial companies (NBFCs), payment aggregators, fintech firms and several other regulated financial entities that provide banking and payment services to millions of customers. The government said the legal framework governing banking evidence needed to evolve to reflect these changes.

One of the key features of the Bill is that it allows bankers' books to be produced in either physical or electronic form during legal proceedings. It formally recognises electronic, digital and virtual records as evidence and introduces a standardised process for certifying such records. The law also permits authentication through manual, digital and electronic signatures, reducing reliance on paper documents while ensuring that digital records meet legal standards.

Another significant provision is 'Clause 4', which empowers the Central government to extend the law to other regulated financial entities through a notification. This is intended to create a uniform evidential framework across the financial sector instead of limiting the provisions to traditional banking institutions. As new forms of regulated financial service providers continue to emerge, the provision allows the legal framework to be expanded without requiring fresh legislation each time.

According to the government, the law has been designed to strengthen confidence in the use of banking records during legal proceedings while protecting customer privacy and confidentiality. By providing legal recognition to digital records, it seeks to reduce uncertainty in cases where electronic banking data is produced as evidence before courts or investigating agencies.

The Bill replaces a law enacted in 1891, when banking records were maintained in ledgers and paper registers. Under the old Act, legal proceedings largely depended on certified copies of physical bank records. Since then, India's banking system has undergone a major transformation, with financial transactions increasingly conducted through internet banking, mobile applications, digital wallets and other electronic platforms. The new legislation seeks to ensure that the legal framework keeps pace with these technological changes.

Members supporting the Bill also highlighted the need for safeguards as the financial sector becomes increasingly digital. Concerns were raised over cyber fraud, identity theft, unauthorised transactions and the possible manipulation of electronic records. Members urged the government to continue strengthening cybersecurity systems associated with banking records so that digital evidence remains reliable and secure.

Data protection and privacy also featured prominently during the dis-

cussion. Members noted that banking records contain sensitive personal and financial information and called for strong safeguards against misuse, unauthorised access and cyber threats. They said protecting customer data would be essential to maintaining public trust as digital records become a routine part of legal proceedings.

The discussion also drew attention to the practical implementation of the law. Suggestions included training judges, investigating agencies, bank officials and enforcement personnel to effectively handle electronic evidence. Members also pointed out that many people in rural and remote areas still depend on conventional banking systems and said implementation of the new law should not create difficulties for them or for smaller financial institutions that are continuing their digital transition.

RS passes

Taxation Bill

Responding to concerns in the Rajya Sabha, she said consumers will continue to make UPI payments free of cost, while any future Merchant Discount Rate (MDR), if introduced, would apply only to a limited category of merchant transactions above a prescribed threshold. The Rajya Sabha returned the Bill to the Lok Sabha with a voice vote, completing the parliamentary process.

Sitharaman said the Bill amends Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, by removing its linkage with the Income Tax Act and allowing the Central government to notify which electronic payment modes or transactions will continue to remain free. She said no MDR framework has been finalised and any decision would be taken later by the UPI and Services Steering Committee headed by NPCI.

"The vast majority of merchant transactions, including ordinary, low-value transactions, will continue to remain free," she said, adding that small merchants remain central to the government's financial inclusion efforts.

Highlighting UPI's growth since its 2016 launch, the minister said India processed 2,366 crore UPI transactions worth Rs 29.9 lakh crore in July 2026 and the platform is now available in 11 countries.

The Bill also replaces the June 5 ordinance granting tax exemption on interest income and capital gains earned by foreign portfolio investors from government securities. It extends tax incentives for electronics manufacturing, eases rules for foreign fund managers and cloud companies using Indian data centres, and seeks to support investment in AI data centres.

Nine killed

According to eyewitnesses, staff from the local administration and villagers present at the scene had warned the driver not to proceed further. But he continued, and within moments, the strong current swept the van into the water.

Villagers, risking their own lives, tied ropes and launched a rescue operation, managing to pull out some of the passengers, they said.

The bodies of nine people, including a girl, were recovered.

Sarangpur SDOP Arvind Singh said rivers and drains were overflowing due to heavy rains on Monday.

The driver carelessly drove the van into the strong current of the drain on the road near the Padana bypass, and it sank in no time, killing nine people, he said, adding that a case has been registered at the Sarangpur police station.

AGENCIES

Ajit Doval

himself as a senior government official and allegedly carried out fraudulent activities across Bihar.

During questioning, Gupta produced a Central Vigilance Commission card and claimed he was working as an undercover agent under NSA Ajit Doval. He also showed an identity card identifying him as an IAS officer. "Preliminary investigation showed that all these claims were fake," Singh said.

A search of Gupta's residence led to the recovery of a Tesla equipped with a full self-driving (FSD) feature and carrying a 'Government of India' board, a Tata Safari, more than 31 litres of imported foreign liquor, large quantities of beer, five Apple iPhones, 20 credit cards, eight debit cards, four cheques-books and other valuables.

"The Tesla car with full self-driving technology feature is a rarity in India," Singh said. Police also recovered two horns believed to belong to a barasingha, or swamp deer. Singh said possession of the horns is punishable under the Wildlife Protection Act.

Police suspect Gupta amassed substantial assets through fraud, deception and corruption. "The assets he acquired were through fraud, deception, or corruption," Singh said.

Investigators are examining Gupta's properties and financial assets and will seek assistance from the Bihar Police's Economic Offences Unit as the probe widens. Police are also investigating how long Gupta had allegedly impersonated an IAS officer, who may have been cheated, and how he acquired the luxury vehicles and other valuables recovered during the raid.

Adopted son of widow inherits share in her husband's property: HC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

PRAYAGRAJ: The Allahabad High Court has observed that a son adopted by a woman after the death of her husband is to be treated as the adopted son of the deceased husband as well and inherits the husband's share in a property.

Justice Chandra Kumar Rai dismissed the petition filed in the year 1983 by one Ram Kripal of Prayagraj challenging the consolidation officer's order that one Ramji, who was adopted son of Moti Rani and Muralidhar will inherit his father's share in a property.

As per facts, one Murlidhar died issueless and his share devolved to his widow, Moti Rani. Ramji claimed that Rani had adopted him by an adoption deed dated August 2, 1960 and he had thereby inherited the share of Murlidhar.

The Court relied on the decision of the Supreme Court in 'Sawan Ram vs. Kalawanti' observed, "Considering the ratio of law laid down by Apex Court and this Court, there is no illegality in the exercise of jurisdiction by the consolidation authorities in holding that Ramji will inherit as adopted son of Smt. Moti Rani and Murlidhar".

The court in its judgement dated July 30 also relied on another judgement in the Subhash Misir case in which it was held that the adopted son of a widow would be deemed to be the son of her husband and on her death would inherit the property as the heir of the deceased husband.

AMOL KHOLE SAYS ALL 8 MPs HAD DIFFERENT ISSUES

Lok Sabha MPs of NCP (SP) meet PM Modi, discuss Maharashtra issues

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A delegation of all Lok Sabha MPs from the NCP, led by party's working president Supriya Sule, on Monday met Prime Minister Narendra Modi and discussed with him various issues related to Maharashtra.

The NCP (SP) said the party MPs discussed with the Prime Minister pending matters and placed before him the problems faced by the people in Maharashtra.

"We have discussed Maharashtra issues," Sule told news agency.

The contentious FCRA Amendment Bill did not figure in the meeting, which lasted for about 15 minutes, sources said.

Sule has been opposing the Bill in its present form.

Her MP colleague Amol Khole said all eight MPs of the NCP (SP) had different issues



PM Narendra Modi during a meeting with a delegation of NCP (SP) MPs led by party Working President Supriya Sule, in New Delhi

concerning their respective constituencies, ranging from policy decisions to matters related to river interlinking.

"There were also concerns regarding the railways. For instance, a massive protest took place yesterday over the Pune-Nashik semi-high-speed rail, along with issues concerning farm loan waivers. We raised

all these matters when we met Prime Minister Narendra Modi today," he told reporters.

Khole, however, made it clear that no discussion took place on parliamentary proceedings, which have been disrupted since the Monsoon session began on July 20.

"Due to disruptions in Parliament, we were unable to

raise our concerns and that is why we took them up with PM Modi. PM Modi was very warm, listened to us patiently and assured us that action would be taken," he said.

Sources also said the NCP (SP) MPs raised with the prime minister issues related to drought, onion prices, pollution in the Chandrabhaga river,

Highlights

- » The contentious FCRA Amendment Bill did not figure in the meeting, which lasted for about 15 minutes, sources said
- » 'MPs discussed with the PM pending matters and placed before him the problems faced by the people in Maharashtra'

Flags should not be thrown on ground or discarded: MHA

Directs all the states and UTs to adhere to Flag Code

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Union home ministry directed all the states and Union territories on Monday to adhere to the Flag Code, underlining that while flags made of paper may be waved by the public on occasions of important national, cultural and sports events, those should not be discarded or thrown on the ground after the events.

In a communique to the chief secretaries of all the states and Union territories, the Union Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) said a perceptible lack of awareness is often noticed amongst people as well as organisations and agencies of the government with regard to laws, practices and conventions that apply to the display of the national flag.

"I am directed to say that the Indian National Flag represents hopes and aspirations of the people of our country and hence should occupy a



position of honour," it said. It asked the states to undertake mass awareness programmes in this regard and give those wide publicity through advertisements in the electronic and print media.

The ministry said the national flag should be hand spun and hand woven or machine made, and the material used should be cotton, polyester, wool, silk or khadi bunting.

"A member of the public, a private organisation or an edu-

cational institution may hoist/display the National Flag on all days and occasions, ceremonial or otherwise, consistent with the dignity and honour of the National Flag. The Flag Code of India, 2002, was amended vide Order dated 19th July, 2022.... Where the Flag is displayed in open or displayed on the house of a member of the public, it may be flown day and night," the Flag Code attached with the order said.

It made it clear that whenever the national flag is displayed, it should occupy a position of honour and should be distinctly placed, and a damaged or dishevelled flag shall not be displayed.

The communique said the flag should not be flown from a single masthead simultaneously with any other flag or flags.

"The Flag should not be flown on any vehicle except of the dignitaries mentioned in Section IX of Part III of the Flag Code, such as President,

LS passes Bill to set up panel to appoint chiefs, members of tribunals

Bill was passed without a debate amid din of Opposition protest

NEW DELHI: A Bill to set up a commission to select chairpersons and members for various tribunals was passed in the Lok Sabha without a debate on Monday, amid the din of Opposition protest.

According to the Tribunals Reforms Bill, 2026, its key aim is to improve efficiency, ensure independence, transparency and uniformity in the qualification and appointment of chairpersons and members of various tribunals.

Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal introduced the Bill amid noisy protests by Opposition members seeking the presence of Union Home minister Amit Shah over the police crack-



MoS Arjun Ram Meghwal speaks in the Lok Sabha, in New Delhi, PTI

down on students during the July 20 protest here against the NEET paper leak.

When the Bill came up for consideration and passage, it was passed by a voice vote without a debate as the Opposition protests drowned the House proceedings.

In brief remarks, Megh-

wal made it clear that the draft law does not change or alter the jurisdictions of the various tribunals but only makes the appointment process uniform.

He said the Bill is a part of the "reform express" of the Modi government.

Members who had given notices to oppose the Bill at the introduction stage chose not to speak amid the din.

The Bill also lays the framework to set up a National Tribunals Commission.

To be headquartered in the national capital, the proposed commission will consist of a chairperson and four members -- two judicial members and two technical members. MPOST

'Asiatic lion population up from 523 in 2015 to 891 in 2025'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Asiatic lion population in India steadily increased from 523 in 2015 to 891 in 2025, Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav said on Monday.

Marking World Lion Day 2026, in a post on X, the minister said that the success in conserving the Asiatic lion is a proud testament to the country's commitment to wildlife and biodiversity.

"From protecting critical habitats to strengthening conservation efforts, India has demonstrated that development and nature conservation can move forward together," Yadav said. "As we mark World Lion Day, let us reaffirm our resolve to safeguard our natural heritage and ensure that the roar of the Asiatic Lion continues to resonate for generations to come," he added.

The Project Lion was announced by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on August 15, 2020, to ensure long-term conservation of the big cat.

Currently, the lion range has expanded from around 30,000 sq km in 2020 to nearly 35,000 sq km. The project adopts a landscape-level, holistic approach to biodiversity conservation, emphasising habitat enhancement, disease monitoring and veterinary support, scientific population tracking, technology-aided interventions, biodiversity protection, benefit sharing and community involvement.

STUDENTS' PROTEST IN BIHAR Cong's 'fact-finding teams' allege 'police brutality' against protesting students

NEW DELHI: Congress fact-finding teams investigating police action against students in Bihar have documented instances of severe brutality, including the firing of AK-47 rifles at peaceful protesters, the party claimed in a press conference on Monday.

Senior Congress leader Krishna Allavaru, Bihar in-charge, said the six Congress teams uncovered a "reign of terror" unleashed against students attempting to suppress their morale. The party released visuals purporting to show policemen beating students and pointing firearms at them. In Siwan district, Allavaru said,

'Six Congress teams uncovered a "reign of terror" unleashed against students attempting to suppress their morale'

AK-47 rounds were fired at protesting youth, injuring three students, one with a bullet wound to the neck, another to the shoulder.

"Who authorised the use of AK-47 against civilians?" Allavaru demanded, questioning whether orders came from Bihar Chief Minister or Union Home minister. He said both should

resign if the action was authorised at their level.

Allavaru highlighted a pointed question from Bihar youth to Prime Minister Narendra Modi: if 1,000 acres of prime land can be leased to a private entity at Re 1 annually, why can't recruitment examination fees be fixed at Re 1? He noted students currently pay Rs 500-850 per examination, imposing financial hardship on lakhs of aspirants.

Congress MP Imran Pratapgarhi disclosed that despite the Bihar government's notification withdrawing cases against students, police continued hounding them over old cases registered years earlier. MPOST

MP to set up industrial security forces, establish special units for PVTG youth

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: The Madhya Pradesh government will set up three State Industrial Security Forces and establish special units for youth from Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTGs), Chief Minister Mohan Yadav announced on Monday.

Yadav made the announcement while addressing a Police Department felicitation programme in Bhopal, where police officers and personnel thanked him for opening up long-pending promotion avenues and undertaking large-scale recruitment in the force.

The Chief Minister said three State Industrial Security Forces would be formed in Madhya Pradesh, with one to be constituted in the first phase.

He also announced special companies for youth from the Baiga, Bharia and Saharia PVTGs, aimed at creating dedicated employment opportunities for members of the three tribal communities.

Yadav also announced the establishment of a new police battalion in Khandwa, as part of efforts to expand and strengthen the state's police



Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav

infrastructure.

Highlighting the government's focus on strengthening the police force, Yadav said 27,534 police officers and personnel across 58 cadres had been promoted.

The promotions included 12,928 constables elevated to head constables and 5,171 head constables promoted to assistant sub-inspectors.

He said more than 14,704 candidates had been selected for various police posts since 2023, while recruitment for another 9,751 posts was underway.

Recruitment for the Police Band and Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) is also in its final stages.

Yadav said the government was committed to improving the morale and welfare of police personnel, who work under demanding conditions to maintain law and order.

"The police should discharge their duties, while the government will fulfil its responsibilities towards your families," he said, urging personnel to work with integrity, sensitivity, discipline and impartiality.

Director General of Police Kailash Makwana said recruitment to several newly sanctioned posts was in progress. The state had also approved recruitment to 9,662 posts across various categories this year, he said.

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SHANTI SEWA NYAYA

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DP/0900/2026

DONATION ROW: GIVEN 'CLEAN CHIT' AT VHP MEETING

Ram Temple Trust: 'Rai back in Gen Secy race'

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: Champat Rai, who stepped down as general secretary of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust amid allegations related to the alleged theft of temple offerings, is once again emerging as a strong contender for the post, with several influential seers in Ayodhya backing his return.

Rai resigned on June 26 after allegations concerning the handling of donations and offerings at the Ram temple came under scrutiny. However, sources said the issue lost momentum within the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) following its national meeting in Delhi on July 22, where Rai was given a clean chit.

The following day, prominent seers met at Maniram Das Chhawani in Ayodhya



Champat Rai

FILE PIC

and declared Rai "innocent", demanding his reinstatement as general secretary.

Since then, Rai has stepped up his outreach to the seer community, visiting temples across Ayodhya and meeting mahants and religious leaders to discuss the functioning of the Ram temple. The outreach

Apex Court to hear pleas on Aug 17

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday said it would hear on August 17 a batch of petitions seeking a court-monitored SIT probe into the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was apprised by a lawyer that Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who has been appearing for the Uttar Pradesh government, has gone to the United Nations for a function.

The bench deferred the hearing to August 17.

Earlier in the day, the top court agreed to consider the request by the counsel for the Uttar Pradesh government for deferring the hearing on these pleas.

MPOST

is being viewed as an effort to rebuild confidence before the trust takes a final decision.

Swami Rajkumar Das, head of Ramvallabhakunj and a member of the temple's religious committee, said the seer community considered Rai innocent. Rajkumar Das also credited Rai with playing

an important role in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement and temple construction.

The July 23 meeting at the Tulsidas Naturopathy Hospital complex of the Maniram Das Chhawani Trust was attended by Mahant Kamal Nayan Das, Swami Rajkumar Das, Mahant Mithilesh Nandini Sharan,

Akhara Parishad spokesperson Mahant Sanjay Das, Vaishnav Akhara Parishad spokesperson Mahant Gaurishankar Das, Mahant Janardan Das and Mahant Shashikant Das.

The seers highlighted Rai's contribution to the temple movement, described the allegations as part of a conspiracy and sought his reappointment.

Sources also claimed opposition to Rai within the VHP subsidised following signals from its top leadership. His supporters have cited his age, 81, and simple lifestyle while defending him against allegations of financial irregularities.

Rai could be given another opportunity to head the trust within the next two to three months, sources said. The trust deferred the appointment at its July 19 meeting, with its next meeting slated for September 2. Meanwhile, acting gen-

eral secretary Dr Krishnamohan has become more active in managing the trust's affairs. He has been reviewing temple arrangements and recently visited the State Bank of India's Ayodhya branch to review the trust's bank accounts and locker.

VHP international general secretary Bajrang Lal Bagda is also being discussed as a possible candidate. Appointed to the post in February 2024, Bagda represents the VHP's current organisational leadership. The contest remains open, with Rai having the advantage of his longstanding association with the Ram Janmabhoomi movement and support among Ayodhya's seers, while Bagda brings the backing of the VHP's organisational structure.

The final decision will rest with the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

ED initiates probe into Jharkhand examinations 'irregularities' case

RANCHI: The Enforcement Directorate has launched a money laundering investigation into alleged irregularities in the conduct of multiple recruitment examinations in Jharkhand particularly the JSSC-CGL examination, officials said on Monday.

They said the central agency took cognisance of a state police CID FIR and some other complaints and chargesheets to initiate a probe under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

The ED is soon expected to initiate further action, including gathering evidence, summoning those linked to these cases and possibly attaching the accused's assets, officials said.

Students have been agitating in the state for 16 days demanding a CBI probe

into alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations, particularly the JSSC-CGL (Jharkhand General Graduate Level Combined Competitive Examination).

The agitators are also demanding comprehensive reforms in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC).

They are also seeking cancellation of several recruitment tests, including the 14th Jharkhand PSC Civil Services Examination, and an independent probe into the alleged irregularities, either by the CBI or by a panel of retired high court judges from outside the state.

On Monday, the Jharkhand CID arrested ex-JPSC chairperson L Khiangte in connection

with alleged irregularities in recruitment exams.

The CID had earlier questioned Khiangte four times since July 28 and raided 18 locations across Ranchi, Palamu, Hazaribagh, Bokaro and Dhanbad as part of its probe into the alleged recruitment irregularities.

The state agency also arrested 14 people before Khiangte as part of this probe, while the JPSC postponed the Combined Civil Services Mains Examination, scheduled from July 25 to 27, citing "unavoidable circumstances" amid mounting protests.

All three JPSC members -- Ajeeta Bhattacharya, the wife of prominent JMM leader Supriyo Bhattacharyya, Anima Hansda and Jamal Ahmad -- resigned on Sunday.

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Haryana CM Saini launches MSME and Export Promotion Policy 2026

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Monday launched the Haryana Progressive MSME and Export Promotion Policy 2026, targeting more than Rs 55,000 crore in manufacturing investment, creation of over five lakh jobs and a doubling of the state's exports by 2031.

Launching the policy in Karnal, Saini said it had been prepared with "Make in India" and "Make in Haryana" at its core. Vidhan Sabha Speaker Harvinder Kalyan and Industries and Commerce Minister Rao Narbir Singh were among those present. The five-year policy places Haryana's 15 lakh MSMEs at the centre of the state's next phase of economic growth, with 60 initiatives covering finance, infrastructure, technology, innovation, exports,



sustainability and skills. A key reform is the proposed dedicated MSME Directorate to provide focused institutional support. Under the Haryana Udyam Vikas Mission, enterprises in identified thrust sectors will receive incentives including capital investment and interest subsidies, stamp duty reimbursement, employment assistance and support for testing, automation, artificial intelligence and research.

The policy also proposes a State Venture Capital Fund and Sectoral Credit Guarantee Fund to improve access to institutional finance and collateral-free lending. To promote exports, the government will provide assistance for international quality certifications, export credit and insurance, freight, e-commerce registration and participation in global trade fairs. The Mukhya Mantri Pratham Nirayatak Prot-sahan Yojana will support first-time exporters in securing their first international buyer.

The Haryana Niryat Centre will provide a one-stop platform for export documentation, compliance, logistics and market intelligence, while Udaan Dwaar will facilitate international partnerships.

Saini also launched Haryana Udyog Saathi, an AI-powered multilingual policy assistant for entrepreneurs.

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'Vande Mataram' to be sung at Red Fort on I-Day: Official

Celebrations to highlight 'Yuva Shakti'

MPOST BUREAU

TAKEAWAYS

» India will mark its 80th Independence Day on August 15

» 'Vande Mataram' will be sung upon the PM's arrival at the Red Fort

NEW DELHI: In a historic first, the national song 'Vande Mataram' will be sung during the Independence Day celebrations at the iconic Red Fort on August 15, and the event's theme will be the contributions of youth power toward making India a developed nation by 2047, the government announced on Monday.

Defence Secretary R K Singh, addressing a press conference, said the plan to celebrate the success and contribution of youths during the event "predates" the students' protest at the Jantar Mantar.

"Youths are a critical part of our journey towards Viksit Bharat because they will both be contributing to it and will be hopefully gaining from it. That is the only reason," he said. "The plan to celebrate the success and contribution of youth at the Independence Day celebrations predates any other event," Singh said.

"I can assure you that this planning predates the Jantar Mantar agitation," he added.

India will mark its 80th Independence Day on August 15, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi leading the celebrations from the Red Fort in Delhi. Singh stated that as 2026 marks 150 years of 'Vande Mataram', the national song that inspired millions during the freedom struggle, will be sung from the rampsarts of the Red Fort for the first time as a tribute to its enduring legacy.

'Vande Mataram' will be sung upon the prime minister's arrival at the Red Fort. Thereafter, he will unfurl the national flag and deliver the customary address to the nation, according to the defence secretary.

The celebrations this year will also commemorate 'Yuva Shakti' (youth power), acknowledging the contribution of young India in building a 'Viksit Bharat' by 2047, he added. A Mi-17 helicopter of the Indian Air Force will carry a banner commemorating 150 years of 'Vande Mataram and shower flower petals over the people gathered at the Red Fort.

To a question, the defence secretary said Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi has been invited to the event and the seating arrangements for the invitees will be strictly followed as per the Table of Precedence (ToP).

Singh said as per ToP, Gandhi's seat will be after the cabinet ministers.

The Independence day celebrations will acknowledge the success of youth in different spheres, another defence ministry official said. "Achievements of 19 medallist students of International Physics, Chemistry, Biology and Mathematical Olympiad 2026 is an example of the success of Yuva Shakti in the field of science. They have been invited for the function and will be seated on the rampart," the official said.

Approximately 5,000 special guests, who are achievers from different walks of life and are guiding the country in its 'Viksit Bharat' journey, have been invited as special guests for the celebrations, he said.

Maha: Snake bites 6 girls at school; three dead

GADCHIROLI: Three tribal girls died and as many others were undergoing treatment after a venomous snake bit them at a residential school in Maharashtra's Gadchiroli, prompting the district administration to launch an inquiry into the incident, officials said on Monday.

The incident occurred around midnight on Sunday in the hostel of the aided tribal residential school, located in Japtalai village, about 10 km from Dhanora taluka headquarters, a district administration official said.

A venomous snake bit the minors while they were sleeping on the floor in the school's hostel. Three of them, aged 8, 12 and 14, died. Three other girls, in the age group of 11 to 14, were receiving treatment for snakebite, he said.

District Collector Avishyant Panda said a detailed inquiry will be conducted to ascertain exactly how the incident occurred, whether adequate protective measures were in place at the students' accommodation, and whether the school management complied with required safety rules and precautions. A thorough inspection of the school's safety arrangements will be done, he said, while expressing sorrow over the incident.

Three students were undergoing treatment. They were promptly administered the anti-venom medicines, and medical teams were closely monitoring their condition, he said. The collector instructed the district surgeon to ensure no deficiencies in treatment and that the students receive special care.

Teams from the Tribal Development Department will inspect the site and gather necessary information. If negligence or safety lapses are found during the probe, responsibility will be fixed, and action will be taken against the guilty as per rules, Panda said.

Gadchiroli's co-guardian minister Ashish Jaiswal also expressed sorrow over the incident.

MPOST

e-Visa scheme now covers 88 ports

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The government has authorised 11 more international ports — nine land ports and two airports — for entry of foreign nationals holding e-Visas, expanding the reach of the electronic visa facility.

With the latest additions, the total number of international ports authorised for entry of e-Visa holders has risen to 88, comprising 37 airports, 38 seaports and 13 land ports.

The nine land ports added to the list are Agartala, Daranga, Gede, Ghojadanga, Haridaspur, Jaigaon, Dawki, Moreh and Attari (Road). Bhopal and Tirupati airports have also been included.

The government said it has been liberalising, simplifying and streamlining the visa regime while ensuring national security.

The government has authorised 11 more international ports — nine land ports and two airports — for entry of foreign nationals holding e-Visas

According to the government, 95 per cent of e-Visa applications are processed within 72 hours of receipt, highlighting the increasing use of technology in the system.

Launched in 2014 for citizens of 43 countries, the e-Visa facility is now available to nationals of 172 countries.

The scheme has emerged as an important component of India's visa policy, with nearly 78 per cent of all visas issued by Indian missions abroad being e-Visas.

The e-Visa facility is available under 17 categories, including Tourist, Business, Medical, Mountaineering, Student, Transit, Miscellaneous and Group Visa for cruise passengers, besides other sub-categories.

Officials said the government has taken the initiative on the direction of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah to make India's visa regime more liberalised and accessible to legitimate foreign visitors without compromising security.

The addition of the 11 ports will provide e-Visa holders with more entry options through international border crossings as well as the newly included airports.

The Centre said the expansion would further improve convenience for foreign visitors while maintaining efficiency and security in the visa system.

SWATI MAHAJAN

CHANDIGARH: Haryana's bureaucracy has witnessed frequent reshuffles over the past year, with around 55 transfer orders issued between August 2025 and August 2026. The latest rejig has once again brought the frequent movement of senior officials into focus, after an IAS officer was transferred twice within 24 hours.

IAS officer Pradeep Dahiya was on August 6 transferred from his post as Commissioner, Municipal Corporation Gurugram (MCG), and appointed Deputy Commissioner, Rohtak, according to an order uploaded on the Haryana Chief Secretary portal. However, within 24 hours, the government reversed the decision and retained Dahiya as MCG Commissioner, Gurugram.

The reversal came as part of a major bureaucratic reshuffle on August 7, in which 17

INSIGHT

» 55 transfer orders issued between Aug 2025 & Aug 2026

» Some transfers were reversed within a day

senior IAS officers and seven HCS officers — 24 officials in all — were transferred or given new assignments.

The latest instance is not the first time that postings have been changed within a day. In June this year, three bureaucrats saw their assignments revised within 24 hours.

Prabhjot Singh was transferred from Director General, Technical Education, to Director General, State Transport, on June 25. The following day, he was shifted again and appointed DG Environment and Secretary, Environment.

Similarly, IFS officer S Narayanan was transferred

from Higher Education to Environment on June 25, only to be moved back to Higher Education on June 26.

IAS officer Virender Kumar Dahiya was also transferred on June 25 from Environment/State Transport to Higher/Technical Education. His orders were revised the next day and he was assigned State Transport.

Pradeep Dahiya, meanwhile, had been appointed MCG Commissioner on May 6, 2025. His proposed stint as DC Rohtak lasted only a day before the government restored his previous assignment.

The August 7 reshuffle also saw additional charges being assigned to senior bureaucrats. G Anupama was given additional charge of Youth Empowerment and Entrepreneurship, while C G Rajini Kaanthan was assigned Finance, the Central Committee of Examinations and Haryana Medical Educa-

tion and Research.

A review of government transfer orders shows that the reshuffles have remained frequent since August 2025. There were two transfer orders in August 2025, two in September, five in October and one in November. December witnessed six orders.

In January 2026, five transfer orders were issued, followed by around five in February, two in March, four in April, five each in May and June, seven in July, and four in August so far.

This comes even as the state government notified the Haryana Model Online Transfer Policy, 2026, on June 25, which aims to ensure a transparent and merit-based mechanism for transfers of regular employees and improve administrative efficiency. However, the policy excludes All India Services and Haryana Civil Services (Executive Branch) and Allied Services from its purview.

Nation Briefs

CISF DETAINS 4 'B'DESHIS' IN AGARTALA, SEIZES 1.31 KG GOLD IN MUMBAI

NEW DELHI: The CISF on Sunday detected four suspected Bangladeshi nationals at Maharaja Bir Bikram Airport in Agartala and intercepted 1.31 kg of gold at Mumbai airport in separate incidents. At Agartala, CISF personnel noticed two women behaving suspiciously. They had entered the Security Hold Area after checking in for an Air India Express flight to Kolkata. Tripura Police immigration personnel later detained the two women and noticed two more suspected Bangladeshi nationals. All four were handed over to airport police for further action. At Mumbai airport, CISF's Crime Intelligence Wing intercepted an airport loader allegedly receiving four gold capsules weighing 1,311 grams from a passenger arriving from Dubai. Both were handed over to Customs and the Air Intelligence Unit for further investigation.

MAHA: STRAY DOG ATTACKS NEARLY 130 PEOPLE IN 7 HOURS IN KALYAN

THANE: A suspected rabid stray dog attacked nearly 130 people within seven hours in Kalyan (West) on Sunday, leaving 25 requiring hospitalisation and an 11-year-old girl needing advanced treatment, officials said on Monday. The attacks began around 2 pm near a hotel, with the dog reportedly targeting pedestrians, two-wheeler riders and auto-rickshaw passengers. Panic spread across Birla College Road, Old RTO Office and Bhoirwadi. Residents accused KDMC of delayed action and demanded an inquiry.



EDITORIAL
EMPOWERING
SMALL
BUSINESSES

The Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026 addresses a persistent problem confronting India's small businesses: getting paid on time. Parliament has cleared the Bill after the Rajya Sabha passed it on August 3 and the Lok Sabha followed on August 7. It amends the MSME Development Act, 2006, with changes covering delayed payments, registration, dispute resolution, penalties and the classification of enterprises. For millions of small businesses, these may sound like procedural changes, but their implications are considerable. MSMEs frequently operate with thin cash buffers, making an unpaid invoice more than an accounting inconvenience. It can prevent a firm from paying workers, purchasing raw materials or servicing loans. The amendment therefore attempts to strengthen the institutional machinery around the sector rather than merely announce another credit or subsidy scheme.

Perhaps the most consequential provision concerns payments from Central Public Sector Enterprises (CPSEs). The Bill requires CPSEs to settle invoices for goods and services purchased from MSMEs through the RBI-regulated Trade Receivables Discounting System, or TReDS. The Centre may extend this requirement to other authorities or entities, while states may similarly bring their public enterprises and other bodies under the mechanism. TReDS allows an MSME to use an accepted invoice to obtain financing from financiers rather than wait for the buyer to eventually release the money. Making the platform part of the public-sector payment architecture can therefore improve visibility and potentially shorten the working-capital cycle. The real test, however, will be whether invoice acceptance itself happens promptly. Digitising a delayed process cannot by itself eliminate delay if large buyers retain the ability to postpone acknowledgement of supplies or contest invoices. Implementation must ensure that TReDS becomes a genuine payment discipline rather than another compliance portal.

The second major reform concerns disputes. Under the amended framework, mediation before a Micro and Small Enterprises Facilitation Council or mediation service provider must be completed within 90 days from the date fixed for the first appearance. If mediation fails, the matter must be referred to arbitration within 30 days of its termination, and the arbitral award must ordinarily be made within 90 days after pleadings are completed. The Bill also enables the Centre to establish mechanisms for online mediation and arbitration. Importantly, when a buyer challenges an award, the existing framework requires a 75 per cent deposit. The amendment goes further: if the court case remains pending beyond six months, at least 50 per cent of the awarded amount must be released to the MSME supplier from the deposit. This matters because a legal victory that produces no cash for years offers little comfort to a small enterprise struggling to survive. Faster dispute resolution and interim access to money could change the bargaining balance between small suppliers and much larger purchasers.

There is also an important ease-of-doing-business component. Registration is to become voluntary for all MSMEs, with the Centre notifying a free national digital platform and states permitted to establish their own platforms. The Bill also changes the statutory classification framework, empowering the Centre to classify micro, small and medium enterprises using both investment and turnover criteria, with limits prescribed through notification rather than embedded in the Act. Another notable shift is towards decriminalisation. Certain contraventions move to a warning-and-monetary-penalty regime. Wilfully providing false registration information, for example, can attract a warning on the first occasion and graded penalties thereafter. Failure by buyers to disclose unpaid MSME dues in annual accounts will similarly attract escalating penalties after an initial warning. An adjudicatory and appellate mechanism is also provided, with the Development Commissioner acting as adjudicating officer and appeals lying before the MSME Secretary. The broader philosophy is sensible: punish deliberate or repeated non-compliance without turning routine business regulation unnecessarily criminal.

Ultimately, the Bill should be judged not by how many provisions it changes but by whether it alters everyday commercial behaviour. India has long recognised delayed MSME payments as a problem; the difficulty has been converting legal protection into money in the entrepreneur's bank account. Mandatory TReDS settlement for CPSE procurement, fixed dispute-resolution timelines and partial payment during prolonged challenges are therefore potentially significant interventions. Yet institutions will determine outcomes. Facilitation Councils will need sufficient members, technology and administrative capacity to meet statutory timelines, while government entities and large buyers must not find new procedural routes to postpone invoice acceptance. Small firms will also need awareness and affordable access to the new digital and dispute-resolution mechanisms. The 2026 amendment is consequently best understood as an attempt to move MSME policy from protection on paper towards enforceable commercial discipline. If implemented rigorously, its greatest contribution may be remarkably straightforward: ensuring that a small business which has supplied a product or completed a service is not forced to become an unwilling lender to its customer.

NEW
MARKETS



DEBASHIS SEN

THE WRITER
IS A FORMER
ADDITIONAL CHIEF
SECRETARY

An AI-powered land exchange could convert fragmented records into a credible marketplace while keeping final verification with licensed brokers and regulators

Unlocking Bengal's Dead Capital

Bengal can combine digitised records, licensed intermediaries and AI-based screening to create a transparent, regulated marketplace for land



The AI Land Exchange can connect landowners, industries and brokers within a regulated marketplace alongside CSE

Poorly maintained land records result in a large number of land ownership-related litigations in India. As per NITI Aayog, India ranks 154th on the indicator of Registering Property in the World Bank's Doing Business Survey, 2019. This has an adverse effect on the supply of capital and credit for investment and affects Ease of Doing Business for entrepreneurs. West Bengal's agricultural, peri-urban, urban, and industrial land parcels across the state sit locked away as dead capital. Hard to value, and harder to sell. The state has tried to fix this. A land bank of government-vested plots was assembled, but it amounted to little more than a collection of maps of scattered parcels. A cumbersome allotment policy, layered on top of land ceiling laws, left the land bank underutilised. Private start-ups have since tried the opposite approach using open platforms where any seller could upload a plot and any buyer could browse. But without verification, litigated land, already-sold land, non-existing plots, and encroached-upon land ended up being listed alongside clean-title land, and buyers had no way to tell them apart.

The lesson is that a land market cannot be opened up for housing, industry or urbanisation without a regulatory architecture that carries the force of law. NITI Aayog had recommended a draft Conclusive Land Titling Act for states to adopt. This was in 2020, but no state has implemented it. However, now in the era of Artificial Intelligence, Bengal can explore opening up the land market. **How an AI Land Exchange would work**

Any landowner willing to sell may register the intent to sell through a registered broker. No landowner would be allowed to place an offer to sell a plot on the exchange directly, just as no retail investor can walk onto the floor of the National Stock Exchange and enter a "sell" order by themselves. Such authorised brokers may be scheduled banks with dedicated land desks or registered legal firms. Both may be required to meet a prescribed minimum net worth and to post a security deposit with a new Land Regulatory Board (LRB) to be formed on the lines of SEBI. The broker would be responsible for verifying the authenticity of the land offer on display. The land-market equivalent of a merchant banker certifying an IPO prospectus in the SEBI framework could be implemented. Professional bodies like CRISIL or ICRA could publish circle-wise demand indices like a land-market Sensx or Nifty.

Settlement, which is the actual transfer of title and possession, would run digitally through the same brokers, integrated with the state's Registration & Stamp Revenue directorate on one side and the Land Reforms Department's Banglarbhum portal on the other, so that a matched trade automatically triggers electronic mutation and stamp duty collection rather than a separate, manual visit to a registrar's office. A few amendments to the Registration Act, 1908, the Indian Stamp Act, 1899, and the IT Act, 2000, may be necessary for this.

None of this requires the LRB to touch land use. The Land Use and Development Control Plan, or conversion of land character, may remain with the existing revenue and urban-planning authorities. The LRB's job would be narrower and more SEBI-like, to regulate the marketplace, the intermediaries, and the disclosure standards. **A missing piece of a policy direction**

In March 2024, SEBI notifi-

fied the Small and Medium Real Estate Investment Trust (SM-REIT) amendment to the REIT Regulations, 2014. The SM-REIT is an investment vehicle that allows investors to own a share of the income generated by income-generating commercial real estate without buying an entire property. The Infrastructure Investment Trust (InvITs) is a similar collective fund, which enables direct investment of money from individual and institutional investors in infrastructure projects.

However, raw land, agricultural land, non-agricultural land, and peri-urban/city land are not covered. To bring these unregulated and informal land markets into a licensed, disclosure-based framework, a Land Regulatory Board and a Digital AI Land Exchange may be established.

The digital blocks for this are also largely in place. The Unique Land Parcel Identification Number, or Bhū-Aadhaar, assigns a 14-digit georeferenced identifier to individual land parcels under the central Digital India Land Records Modernisation Programme, which has been running since 2008. The SVAMITVA scheme has used drone surveys to map rural residential land parcels. West Bengal's own Banglarbhum portal already has digitised land records. Now we need to add a marketplace and regulatory layer that turns verified data into a tradable, bankable asset.

Other countries offer a useful reality check on what digitisation of land records can and cannot

deliver on its own. Sweden's land registry authority, Lantmäteriet, piloted a blockchain-based property-transaction system estimated to save over €100 million annually once fully implemented, largely by reducing paperwork and processing time. Georgia partnered with a private technology provider to put more than 1.5 million land titles on a blockchain by 2018, giving citizens cryptographically verifiable proof of ownership and materially reducing the scope for duplicate or fraudulent registration.

Closer home, in New Town Kolkata, Non-Fungible Tokens (NFTs) were associated with land plots in a pilot Proof-of-Concept project. The gains came from pairing digitisation with a clear legal mandate that can make the digital record authoritative. That is precisely what a DLE and an LRB, backed by statute, would supply in Bengal.

What Bengal would actually gain

A dedicated "West Bengal Land Exchange and Land Regulatory Board Act" can grant LRB rule-making, licensing, and enforcement powers analogous to those under the SEBI Act, 1992. It would unlock dead capital by converting the State's largest, least liquid asset class into something transparent and bankable. A published, zone-wise land price index would give banks, government valuers and ordinary citizens a credible reference point, reducing the under- and over-valuation disputes that plague collateral-backed lending today. Fractional ownership would allow smaller investors and diaspora Bengalis to invest in land wealth without buying an entire parcel, echoing the access that SM-REITs already provide in commercial real estate buildings. And because settlement would run through the exchange, stamp duty and registration collection would become harder to evade, a genuine revenue gain for the state.

The FinTech Hub in New Town is progressing steadily. Close by, the Calcutta Stock Exchange (CSE) already has a 5-acre plot in the Central Business District of New Town. On 22 June 2026, presenting the state's first budget under its new government, Finance Minister Dr Swapan Dasgupta announced

that West Bengal would support the revival of the CSE, which had been dormant since the Securities and Exchange Board of India suspended trading on its platform in April 2013. CSE, which had itself filed for a voluntary exit only last year, has now asked SEBI to keep that application on hold and await "guidance" on a comeback. It is a nostalgic instinct, and will mean a lot for a city that once ran India's second-largest bourse. But it can be co-terminus with the setting up of a Digital Land Exchange.

To formalise the land market and enable new industries, data centres, GCCs, and housing to emerge, the Digital Land Exchange could be created alongside. The technical foundations (ULPIN, SVAMITVA, Banglarbhum and SEBI's own SM-REIT and InvIT) are in place. The AI layer is now a reality. The AI engine can run on, for example, Claude Sonnet 5, operating under an MoU granting it access to Banglarbhum, eRegistration, and court filing records. Within these permissions, it can assign an indicative Title Score with itemised flags (clean chain/mutation pending/litigation reference unresolved), functioning as a screening layer rather than a certifying authority. This works far more reliably once ULPIN/Bhu-Aadhaar rollout is complete across the state, giving the engine a common key to match records across the three siloed systems. Even so, the basic onus of verification would remain with the licensed broker, with the LRB exercising regulatory oversight over both the broker's certification and the AI engine's findings.

NITI Aayog Vice Chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri has recently (6 August 2026) commented that "factor market imperfection, especially in land and capital, is a major impediment" to industrial growth. NITI Aayog's own Land Titling Scheme has been a non-starter for years. A marketplace layer in the AI Land Exchange, alongside the new CSE, can connect landowners, industries, and brokers within a regulatory framework. This can reduce this impediment to a large extent.

Views expressed are personal

REFORM
AGENDA



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The amendment's broader significance extends beyond examination administration. It concerns the relationship between merit and constitutional democracy

From Legislation to Enforcement

India's tougher anti-paper-leak law raises penalties and speeds up trials, but its credibility will ultimately depend on effective enforcement



A stronger law does not, by itself, produce a more trustworthy examination system

On July 31, 2026, President Draupadi Murmu gave assent to the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Act, 2026, amending the 2024 law of the same name barely two years after it came into force. The timing is not incidental. The amendment followed the cancellation and re-conduct of NEET-UG 2026 earlier in the year, weeks of nationwide student protest over renewed reports of paper leaks, and the resignation of the Union Education Minister on July 25, 2026. Parliament moved with unusual speed to pass the amendment bill within days. It is still to be seen whether the amended law is a considered institutional response or a reflexive one drafted under public pressure. The amendment's substance suggests the former, but whether it will actually work has been left almost entirely to implementation.

Coming in the wake of repeated paper leaks that affect examinations for recruitment and higher education admissions, the new amendments manifest a growing recognition that examination fraud is no longer an isolated criminal act but an organised crime capable of undermining governance, economic development, and social justice.

For millions of young Indians, public examinations represent far more than an academic exercise, as they determine their access to higher education, government employment, and opportunities for social mobility. In a country where public sector recruitment remains highly competitive and educational qualifications often define career growth, the integrity of examinations is directly associated with the constitutional promise of equality under Articles 14 and 16. **What changes**

The 2024 Act was India's first standalone criminal statute targeting organised examination fraud, covering examinations run by the Union Public Service Commission, the Staff Selection Commis-

sion, Railway Recruitment Boards, the Institute of Banking Personnel Selection, the National Testing Agency, and other notified authorities. The 2026 amendment tightens that framework on three fronts.

First, the amendment significantly enhances the penal framework under the existing law. For offences under Section 10(1), the term of imprisonment is increased from three to five years to five to ten years, while the maximum fine is raised from ₹10 lakh to ₹50 lakh. Service providers found complicit in the use of unfair means face an enhanced maximum fine of ₹5 crore, up from ₹1 crore, and the period of debarment from participation in public examinations is extended from four years to eight years. Directors, senior management personnel, and other persons in charge of such service providers are now subject to a minimum term of five years' imprisonment and a fine of ₹5 crore. For organised crime under Section 11, the minimum term of imprisonment is increased from five to seven years, while the minimum fine is raised from ₹1 crore to ₹10 crore. By prescribing a statutory minimum of ₹10 crore for organised crime, the amendment clearly differentiates organised examination fraud from other categories of offences and reflects the legislature's intention to impose the most severe sanctions on organised criminal syndicates.

Second, the investigations, whether conducted by local police, a

central investigating agency, or the newly empowered Special Task Force, must conclude within 60 days. Trials before the newly mandated Special Fast Track Courts, one to be designated by every State and Union Territory in consultation with the concerned High Court, must proceed day-to-day and conclude within three months of the chargesheet. Courts are barred from granting adjournments beyond the next working day unless it's necessary, after recording reasons in writing.

All pending cases under the 2024 Act transfer automatically to these new courts, and every State and Union Territory must appoint Special Public Prosecutors exclusively for these trials. Third, on appellate structure. A dedicated appeal now lies before a two-judge Division Bench of the High Court, which is expected to dispose of the appeal "as far as possible" within three months of admission.

However, the legislation alone cannot restore public confidence. A criminal law, however stringent, remains reactive. It punishes misconduct after the damage has already occurred. The real challenge is preventing breaches before they affect the examination process. **Limits of deterrence**

The amendment is built on a straightforward deterrence theory by raising the cost of organised exam fraud to the point that rational actors within cheating syndicates will be dissuaded from participating. A 60-day investigation clock

and a three-month trial clock, if actually met, address a documented failure in the Indian criminal justice system where cases drag on for years, evidence degrades, and networks reconstitute themselves faster than courts can convict their previous iteration.

Compressed timelines protect the public interest in swift justice and a 60-day investigation window is workable for cases built on clear digital evidence, such as leaked PDFs, WhatsApp trails, or payment records, but organized examination fraud increasingly involves layered intermediaries, coaching-network operators, and cross-state logistics that can be genuinely difficult to unravel within two months without either compromising thoroughness or expanding investigative shortcuts that later collapse on appeal.

Similarly, a same-day adjournment default, while a legitimate response to the chronic Indian problem of indefinitely stretched trials, will need careful judicial administration to avoid prejudicing defence preparation, particularly for accused persons of limited means who cannot instantly mobilise counsel or expert evidence on a court's compressed schedule.

The guarantee of a fair procedure provided under Article 21 does not become optional because the underlying offence is serious or the public mood is impatient. The amendment's drafters would do well to ensure that the Special Public Prosecutors and Fast Track Courts being created are accompanied by parallel investment in legal aid capacity for accused persons, so that speed does not become a one-sided advantage for the prosecution. **Federalism test**

Public examinations in India sit across a genuinely fragmented institutional landscape, often involving Union agencies, State Public Service Commissions, recruitment boards, universities, and professional councils, each with its own security protocols, IT vendors, and institutional maturity. A central

criminal statute can mandate fast-track courts and special prosecutors, but it cannot by itself harmonise the preventive infrastructure across 28 states and 8 Union territories with wildly uneven administrative capacity. The more durable fix likely requires a cooperative federalism instrument, perhaps a model framework of minimum-security standards for examination authorities, developed through consultation between the Union government and the States, with technical support and audit resources channelled to less-resourced state agencies rather than assuming uniform capacity across all states.

What counts as success?

The amendment's broader significance extends beyond examination administration. It concerns the relationship between merit and constitutional democracy. At the heart of public confidence in competitive exams lies a simple belief that hard work determines who succeeds. The moment people start doubting this, they do not just lose faith in a single exam such as the NEET; they also question the entire recruitment system, the institutions running it, and even the government appointments that follow.

At the end of the day, the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Act, 2026 should not be seen as the final word on this issue nor as some complete fix. It's an important step in tackling organised exam fraud, but how well it works will come down to its implementation, how seriously technology gets used, whether institutions are held accountable, and a genuine commitment to constitutional values.

A stronger law does not, by itself, produce a more trustworthy examination system. It creates the legal conditions under which trust can be rebuilt, provided implementation, preventive technology, and procedural fairness for the accused are treated as equally serious commitments.

Views expressed are personal

EPICENTRE WAS IN SAN JOSE DEL PALMAR

At least 111 killed as quake of magnitude 7.4 shakes Colombia

BOGOTA: A powerful 7.4 magnitude earthquake struck western Colombia on Monday, killing at least 111 people, trapping residents under debris of collapsed buildings and forcing people to evacuate their homes as far as the capital of Bogota.

The epicentre was in San Jose Del Palmar, a community of about 4,800 people in the Choco region, about 250 miles (400 kilometres) west of Bogota, the U.S. Geological Survey and Colombia's counterpart reported. The USGS said it struck at a depth of 66 miles (107 kilometres).

The quake was also felt in neighbouring Ecuador and Panama, though minimal damage was reported there.

Local officials confirmed that at least 40 people were killed in the department of Risaralda, where the hard-hit city of Pereira is located, and 27 people in the Valle del Cauca department, where Colombia's third-biggest city, Cali, is located.

Two people also died in the city of Manizales.

At least three of those killed in Valle del Cauca were children, the governor said.

The quake left cities across the west of the country — Pereira, Quibdo, Cali and Manizales — ravaged. Residents and search teams picked through the rubble



Residents and rescue workers search through the rubble of a collapsed building after an earthquake struck Cali on Monday

Key Points

» Local officials confirmed that at least 18 people had been killed in the city of Pereira

» Residents picking through the pieces of the rubble amid concerns by authorities of aftershocks

of collapsed buildings amid concerns by authorities of aftershocks. Colombia's interior minister said more than 20 municipalities across the country had been hit.

Colombia's Pacific region

around the quake's epicentre lies along the "Ring of Fire", the line of seismic faults encircling the Pacific Ocean where most of the world's earthquakes occur. Jorge Moncayo, a 64-year-old taxi driver in

Cali, said he saw plumes of dust shoot up across the city as buildings collapsed.

"My entire house shook. I've never lived through such a powerful earthquake," he said. "We're thanking God we're alive."

Colombia's Geological Service said Monday that it had been "the highest magnitude earthquake registered in Colombia in the last decade" and that it had been followed by two 2.8 and 4.8 magnitude aftershocks.

Iran won't reopen Hormuz without US concessions

DUBAI: Iran on Monday said it will not reopen the Strait of Hormuz until the United States met its conditions.

"It is up to the US side to stop and make amends for its illegal and destructive actions," Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said, noting the American blockade of Iranian ports. Iran wants the US to lift the blockade, pay compensation for months of war.

Supreme leader urges 'unity' amid US sanctions: Iran Prez



Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei

DUBAI: Iran's president on Monday said the country's supreme leader has called for "unity and cohesion" as the Islamic Republic faces economic hardships and sanctions stemming from its war with the United States.

The meeting comes amid signs of division among Iran's leaders.

President Masoud Pezeshkian described a nearly seven-hour meeting with Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei in an interview Monday with Iranian state television that aired amid apparent tensions among the Islamic Republic's leaders.

Pezeshkian told the state-run IRIB that he and Khamenei

(US) sanctions". He didn't say when or where they met.

Most important, he said, was Khamenei's emphasis on unity.

"All of the enemy's plans are aimed at creating division," Pezeshkian said. "What we have to do is prevent divisions from emerging."

It is only the second time the Iranian president said he has met with the new supreme leader since Khamenei was appointed in March following a US-Israeli strike that killed his father.

Khamenei, believed to have been wounded in the same attack, has not appeared in public since then.

Ukrainian drone attack on an oil hub deep inside Russia kills 13

KYIV: Ukraine attacked the petroleum hub of Nizhnekamsk in central Russia's Tatarstan region on Monday, killing 13 people and injuring 75 others, local authorities said, in one of the deadliest attacks in the country in the four-year-old war.

The Ukrainian military said it hit an oil refinery in Nizhnekamsk, which is about 1,200 kilometers (750 miles) east of the Ukrainian border and has a population of about 240,000.

Key Points

» The Ukrainian military said it hit an oil refinery in Nizhnekamsk

» The city is home to two refineries and a petrochemical plant

Russian officials didn't say what the drones targeted, but the city is home to two refineries and a petrochemical plant.

Ukraine has targeted Russian oil facilities with long-range drones almost daily in recent months. The campaign has caused fuel shortages in Russia, eaten into its refining capacity and unsettled the population. Also on Monday, several Ukrainian drones sparked a fire at an industrial facility in the Tyumen region of western Siberia, said Governor Alexander Moor, without offering any details.

Last month, Ukrainian drones hit a refinery in Tyu-

men, more than 2,400 kilometers (about 1,500 miles) east of the border with Ukraine.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy says his country is trying to force Russian President Vladimir Putin to the negotiating table and stop his full-scale invasion, launched in 2022.

Russia is one of the world's biggest energy producers.

Ukraine's General Staff said its forces struck a Taneco oil refinery in Nizhnekamsk, starting a fire.

Ebola outbreak started months before it was declared in Congo, says WHO

BUNIA: The fastest-growing Ebola outbreak on record started in February, months before it was officially declared in mid-May, the World Health Organisation said Monday as responders in eastern Congo struggle to catch up.

The WHO regional director for Africa, Dr Mohamed Yakub Janabi, told a news conference that sequencing indicated the outbreak's start. He said some cases early on were wrongly attributed to malaria and typhoid.

"So we are chasing the virus, the virus is ahead of us," Janabi said.

Confirmed cases of Ebola in this outbreak have reached 4,200, including over 1,900 deaths, according to the latest government figures.

BEIJING: China's launch of a rocket carrying a communications satellite on Monday evening was not successful, state media reported, adding that the cause of the failed launch was under investigation.

The ChinaSat 4B satellite aboard a Long March 7A rocket was launched from the coun-

China has launched hundreds of missions using Long March carrier rockets, delivering internet and communication satellites into a pre-set orbit

try's southern island of Hainan, which is home to the Wen-

chang Spacecraft Launch Site, part of China's space program.

The ChinaSat 4B is a communications satellite.

"The rocket experienced an anomaly during the flight and the launch mission failed," the Xinhua news agency said.

It was the first reported Long March 7A failure since its maiden flight in March 2020, when the rocket malfunctioned

after launching from Wenchang, according to Xinhua. China has launched hundreds of missions using Long March carrier rockets, delivering internet and communication satellites into a pre-set orbit. Hainan Island is a popular beach destination off the country's southern coast.

UK, France prepare for another heat wave

EL Nino effect: Western Europe sets new temperature record

PARIS: The UK and France are bracing for the fifth heat wave of the season, adding to an intense stretch of hot weather that has repeatedly sent temperatures soaring across Europe since May.

National weather agency Meteo-France is warning about temperatures approaching 40 degrees Celsius from Tuesday onward in southeastern France. And in the UK, an amber heat health alert for most of England will be in place beginning Tuesday as temperatures are forecast to climb to 36 degrees Celsius later this week.

Across Europe, the extreme heat began in May and has contributed to major wildfires, prolonged drought and new national temperature records, as well as thousands of projected heat-related deaths.

Globally, so far this is the third-hottest year, behind 2024 and 2025, climate statistics show. But 2026 still has time to catch up. Thanks to the one-two punch of accelerated human-caused global warming and a supersized El Nino — a periodic warming of parts of the Pacific that leads to tem-



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

That was partially fueled by developing El Nino conditions in the equatorial Pacific

perature variations around the globe — there's an increasing chance that by the end of the year, 2026 could become the hottest year on record, scientists said.

Last month saw the highest average sea surface temperature ever recorded for July across the extrapolar

oceans, or the oceans free of seasonal sea ice, according to the European climate agency Copernicus.

That was partially fueled by developing El Nino conditions in the equatorial Pacific, the service said. The new average record for July is 20.96 degrees Celsius, which beat the 2023 record of 20.89 degrees Celsius.

But last month's average surface air temperature globally was 16.90 C (62.42 F), making it only the joint second warmest July on record, tied with July 2024, Copernicus reported.

In Western Europe, meanwhile, the average temperature record for the June-July period hit 21.62 degrees Celsius, Copernicus said, topping the 2022 record.

"Persistent high-pressure systems trapped heat over western Europe, and the extreme temperatures also amplified widespread drought. As soils dry out, they lose their ability to provide natural cooling, allowing heat to build more readily," said Samantha Burgess, strategic lead for climate at the European Centre for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts.

"This is a clear example of how climate change is intensifying heat extremes, with heat and drought increasingly reinforcing one another."

In France alone, heat wave alerts were issued for the first time on record in May, when more than half the country recorded new monthly temperature highs.

The heat intensified in June, a period during which at least 5,700 more deaths than usual were recorded, according to France's public health agency.

On the Occasion of Joint Replacement Day

All India Institute of Medical Sciences, New Delhi

Department of Orthopedics

Presents

PUBLIC LECTURE & PANEL DISCUSSION

ON

JOINT REPLACEMENT

Welcome & Introduction

Dr. (Prof.) Nikhil Tandon, Director, AIIMS

Moderator

Dr. (Prof.) Vijay Kumar

Panelists

Dr. (Prof.) Ravi Mittal, Dr. (Prof.) Uma Kumar

Dr. (Prof.) Vimi Rewari, Dr. (Prof.) Srikumar V

• Joint Replacement: Myths, Facts & Advances

• Bone Health

• Pain Free Surgery & Fast Recovery

• Physiotherapy & Mobility Post Surgery

Entry Free

Date : 12.08.2026 (Wednesday)

Time : 04:30 to 05:30 PM

Venue : Jawaharlal Auditorium, AIIMS, New Delhi

No Registration required

All are cordially invited

(Please take your seat by 4:15 PM)

Programme will also be live streamed on YouTube AIIMS Channel

<https://youtube.com/live/FwqCxnMb0E?feature=share>

Please join for tea after the lecture

Parking available at Multi Level Underground Parking (Near Masjid Moth Campus, AIIMS)

For more information please contact:

Protocol Division, AIIMS, New Delhi

Ph: 011- 26593400, 26593514, 26549131

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JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS RAJOURI

E-mail ID: dp.rajouri@jkpolice.gov.in Phone No. 01962- 262224 Fax No.01962-264068

Hue and Cry Notice

Dy. SP Hqrs. Rajouri vide communication No. Hqrs/F-57/2026/10575-77 dated 05.08.2026 has intimated that the alleged accused person namely Aryan S/O Jatinder R/O Dassal Tehsil & District Rajouri is involved in case FIR No. 314/2026 U/S 109/126(2)/191 (2) BNS & 4/25 Arms Act of PS Rajouri, who after committing the offences deliberately evading from police arrest and wanted in the instant case.

Description of the absconding accused is as under:-

1. Name	: Aryan	
2. Parentage	: Jatinder Kumar	
3. Address	: Dassal, Tehsil & District Rajouri	
4. Age	: 20 Years.	
5. Height	: 5'6"	
6. Complexion	: Wheatish	

Therefore, it is requested that a sharp lookout may please be maintained and if any clue regarding the whereabouts of wanted accused person is received, the same may kindly be communicated on below mentioned phone numbers/mail address :-

1. PCR Rajouri	: 01962262515, 01962264493
2. SHO PS, Rajouri	: 9103012703,
3. IC PP City Rajouri	: 9541900746,
4. Dy. SP Hqrs, Rajouri	: 9541900724,
5. DPO Rajouri	: 01962262240,
6. Email address	: dp.rajouri@jkpolice.gov.in

The identity of the informer shall be kept secret and further, if anybody found providing shelter to the wanted accused person or concealing his presence, will also be booked under law.

No. CB/F-55-4/LOC/2026/ 42893-99/DPO

Dated: 08-08.2026

Sr. Superintendent of Police, Rajouri

DIP No:DIP/J-7829/26

AFTER PLANE CRASH China cancels drone shows at tourist sites

BEIJING: China has cancelled scheduled drone shows at tourist attractions across the country amid stepped-up scrutiny of low-altitude aviation following a small plane crash in Beijing that heightened security concerns.

Tourist attractions and event organisers in 11 provinces and regions, including Inner Mongolia, Gansu, Shandong, Guangdong and Hainan, announced last week that drone performances scheduled from Friday onwards have been cancelled, the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post reported on Monday.

The move comes after authorities beefed up aviation security following the crash of a small training plane into a skyscraper in Beijing's business district in June.

The pilot was killed and 13 people were injured in the incident.

The aircraft had entered the main urban area despite restrictions on low-altitude flights, raising concerns over the security risks posed by small aircraft and drones.

India’s Russian crude imports hit record for second month in row

Indian buyers imported Russian crude worth €5.5 billion in July, up 2.1 per cent from June, according to data compiled by the CREA

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India's imports of Russian crude oil rose to a record for the second consecutive month in July, underscoring the country's continued reliance on discounted Russian supplies even as Western sanctions have tightened restrictions on Moscow's energy exports.

Indian buyers imported Russian crude worth €5.5 billion in July, up 2.1 per cent from June, according to data compiled by the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA). Crude accounted for 87 per cent of India's total Russian fossil fuel purchases during the month.

In June, India bought Russian crude worth €4.5 billion, accounting for 83 per cent of its total Russian fossil fuel imports of €5.5 billion. The 2.1 per cent rise is in volume terms and not value.

India's dependence on Russian crude has surged since Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, when Western sanctions and an exodus of European buyers left Moscow offering deep discounts to Asian refiners.

Russia supplied less than 1,00,000 barrels per day to India



Indian refiners imported a record 2.8 million bpd of Russian crude in July 2026, 55.5% of total crude imports

in 2021, or about 2.5 per cent of its crude imports, according to the US Energy Information Administration. The volume rose to about 7,40,000 bpd in 2022 and nearly 1.8 million bpd in 2023, making Russia India's largest crude supplier with about 39 per cent of imports that year.

The dependence has since grown further. Indian refiners imported a record 2.8 million bpd of Russian crude in July 2026, accounting for about 55.5 per cent of total crude imports of just over 5 million bpd. That compares to roughly 1.8 million bpd on average in 2024.

HIGHLIGHTS

» In June, India bought Russian crude worth €4.5 bn euro, accounting for 83% of its total Russian fossil fuel imports of €5.5 bn

» Russia supplied less than 1,00,000 bpd in India in 2021, or about 2.5% of its crude imports

» The volume rose to about 7,40,000 bpd in 2022 and nearly 1.8 million bpd in 2023

“India was the second-largest buyer of Russian fossil fuels in July 2026, importing a total of 6.4 billion euros worth of Russian hydrocarbons. Crude oil constituted 87 per cent of India's purchases, totalling 5.5 billion euros. Coal (512 million euros) and oil products (341 million euro) constituted the remainder of their monthly Russian imports,” CREA said.

The increase in crude purchases in July was driven primarily by a rise in imports through smaller terminals, rather than through India's two largest recipients of Russian crude, Jamnagar and Paradip.

Imports through HMEI Mundra rose 58 per cent from June, while volumes received at Indian Oil's Vadinar SMPL terminal increased 35 per cent. Imports through Mumbai rose 37 per cent. Volumes at Jamnagar, one of the world's largest refining complexes, were unchanged from the previous month, while imports through Paradip fell 22 per cent.

The shift in import flows meant that India's record monthly intake was not dependent on higher volumes at its two largest Russian-crude receiving terminals. Instead, increased receipts at several other ports more than offset the decline at Paradip.

India has emerged as the second-largest buyer of Russian crude since Moscow's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, accounting for 37 per cent of Russia's crude oil exports over the period covered by CREA's analysis, behind China at 50 per cent.

The continued growth in Indian purchases comes as Russia's overall fossil fuel export revenues weakened. Russian crude export revenues were broadly flat in July at €392 million a day, with a 21 per cent monthly decline in pipeline crude earnings offset by a 7 per

cent increase in seaborne crude revenue. The average price of Russia's Urals crude fell 3 per cent in July to \$60.22 a barrel, according to CREA. That remained substantially above the \$44.10-a-barrel G7 and EU price cap that took effect in February 2026.

India's importance to the Russian oil trade extends beyond direct crude purchases. Refineries in India that process Russian crude also remain significant exporters of refined products to countries imposing sanctions on Russia.

In July, refineries in India, Türkiye, Brunei and Georgia that use Russian crude exported oil products worth a combined 633 million euros to sanctioning countries, CREA said. Of that total, €214 million went to the EU, 184 million euros to Australia and 234 million euros to the United States.

CREA estimated that €284 million of those exports were refined from Russian crude.

India was among the largest sources of such shipments. Five cargoes from Indian refineries using Russian crude were unloaded at EU ports in July despite the bloc's ban on imports of oil products made from Russian crude, which took effect on January 21.

Ethanol blending in diesel fails flash-point test: Govt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Ethanol-blended diesel failed required safety specifications because the addition of ethanol sharply lowered the fuel's flash point, Minister of State for Petroleum and Natural Gas Suresh Gopi said on Monday, effectively ruling out the fuel for wider use unless the technical issue is resolved.

Public-sector oil marketing companies conducted scientific evaluations of ethanol blending with diesel through their research and development centres, in collaboration with accredited laboratories and automobile manufacturers, Gopi said in a written reply to Parliament. The tests found that ethanol-blended diesel did not meet the required diesel flash-point specification because the flash point fell sharply in the presence of ethanol, he said.

“Scientific evaluations on blending of ethanol with diesel have been undertaken by Public Sector Oil Marketing Companies through their respective R&D centres in collaboration with accredited laboratories and automobile manufacturers. It was observed that ethanol blended diesel was not meeting diesel flash point as its flash point lowered drastically due to the presence of ethanol,” he said.

The finding comes as India seeks to expand the use of ethanol as a transport fuel and explore new outlets for rising domestic production. The government has so far focused its ethanol blending programme



The finding comes as India seeks to expand the use of ethanol as a transport fuel and explore new outlets for rising domestic production

on petrol and has set a target of 20 per cent blending.

Asked about blending isobutanol in diesel, the minister said, “Isobutanol is presently not being blended with diesel.”

Gopi said no decision has been taken to raise ethanol blending in petrol beyond 20 per cent. Any future increase would be considered only after detailed scientific and technical studies and consultations with automobile manufacturers, oil marketing companies and research institutions.

State-run oil marketing companies floated their first tender in September 2025 to procure about 10.5 billion litres of ethanol for the 2025-26 ethanol supply year. They received offers for nearly 17.6 billion litres, about 68 per cent more

than the quantity sought, and have allocated 10.485 billion litres to 378 registered suppliers.

The government is also examining ethanol as a potential cooking fuel, which could help reduce India's dependence on imported liquefied petroleum gas while making use of surplus domestic ethanol production capacity.

“The use of ethanol as a cooking fuel may emerge as the potential biofuel alternative to fossil fuel based cooking solution which may help in reduction of LPG import dependence and provide clean cooking solution. This may also enable effective utilization of surplus ethanol production capacity in the country,” he said. “The initiative is aligned with the Government's broader objective of promoting cleaner and alternative cooking fuel options.”

The LPG Equipment Research Centre, a joint venture of Indian Oil Corp, Hindustan Petroleum Corp and Bharat Petroleum Corp, along with public-sector oil marketing companies, is working on developing ethanol-based clean cooking alternatives, Gopi said.

The government has introduced several measures to support domestic ethanol production, including interest-subsidy schemes, support for cooperative sugar mills to convert existing sugarcane-based distilleries into multi-feedstock plants, and long-term offtake agreements between oil marketing companies and dedicated ethanol producers.

‘No physical challans needed under advance authorisation’



NEW DELHI: The Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) on Monday said it has removed the requirement of submitting duty payment challans in physical form while applying for Export Obligation Discharge Certificates under the advance authorisation and export promotion capital goods schemes.

It said that licence-wise voluntary duty payment data received from Customs/ICEGATE has been integrated with DGFT's online systems, enabling authenticated verification of such payments directly against the concerned authorisation. “For voluntary duty payments made on or after 1 August 2026, exporters will no longer be required to submit physical challans along with their applications for closure of authorisations,” it said.

The Advance Authorisation Scheme permits duty-free import of inputs that are physically incorporated in the export product, while the EPCG Scheme permits import of capital goods at concessional or zero customs duty, in both cases against an export obligation.

‘Market cap–profit gap for Indian equities to narrow in 18–24 months’

MUMBAI: The gap between market capitalisation and corporate profits for Indian equities is likely to narrow over the next 18-24 months as earnings improve, a senior asset manager said on Monday.

“Over the course of the last three quarters, earnings have started to come in at a much higher rate. And therefore, the gap has kind of reduced between market cap and profit,” said Harish Krishnan, CIO - Equity at Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC, said.

According to the AMC, the profit pool of the top 1,000 listed companies has grown 18 per cent over the last 21 months, while their market capitalisation has remained broadly flat.

Krishnan said the overall markets are doing much better than they were 18-24 months ago and earnings are expected

‘The profit pool of the top 1,000 listed cos has grown 18% over the last 21 months, while their mcap has remained broadly flat’

to improve further.

“We do think that there is a greater prospect of being posted on three-quarters over the course of the next 18-24 months,” he said.

A weaker rupee and trade agreements with several economic blocs could support exports and corporate earnings, he said.

“Along with that, as you are aware, we have now made trade deals with many eco-

nomie blocs and therefore, the weaker currency is going to also represent exports,” Krishnan said.

“The number of companies doing capex is also slowly but surely moving up. So, therefore, I am quite confident about these earnings improving valuations,” he said.

India accounts for around 3 per cent of global market capitalisation share, Krishnan said.

He expects India's share of the global economy to rise to 6-8 per cent or even higher over the next 18 months, creating scope for further convergence between India's economic weight and its share of global market capitalisation.

“It's a compelling opportunity for various international allocators to look at India in a very constructive way,” Krishnan said.

No govt policy restricts airport operators from operating airlines: Minister Murlidhar Mohol

NEW DELHI: The government on Monday informed the Rajya Sabha that there is no policy that restricts airport operators from operating scheduled airlines, but there are certain curbs in agreements related to airports operated under public-private partnerships.

The comments came against the backdrop of reports that the government is looking at allowing airport operators to own airlines, and that Adani Group, which currently operates eight airports, is keen to get into the airline business. The group had denied such reports.

“There is no such government policy restricting operators of major airports from holding substantial equity in

or operating scheduled airlines.

“However, the extant contractual agreements relating to some airports under Public Private Partnership (PPP) contain certain restrictions on scheduled airlines and their group entities/associates from holding equity share of the concessionaires,” Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol said in a written reply to the Rajya Sabha.

The replies were to questions from CPI-M member John Brittas on whether the government is considering any amendment or relaxation of the existing policy restricting operators of major airports from holding substantial equity in or operating scheduled airlines.

The minister also said the Airports Authority of India has received a request seeking waiver of the relevant agreement provision, but the matter “has not yet been examined by the Ministry of Civil Aviation”.

Under the Operation, Management and Development Agreement (OMDA) for major airports operated through public-private partnerships (PPPs), there are restrictions in terms of airport operators having ownership in airlines.

Key airports, including in Delhi and Mumbai, are operated under PPPs where AAI is also a stakeholder. According to reports, Adani Group had written to the AAI seeking relaxations with respect to entering

into the airline business.

On July 24, Adani Group denied media reports and market speculation that it is planning to enter the airline business.

On July 23, IndiGo Co-Founder and Managing Director Rahul Bhatia said there would be a “massive conflict of interest” if airport operators are allowed to own airlines.

On August 5, Akasa Air CEO Vinay Dube said that the airline will be supportive of a proposal to allow airport operators to own airlines, as the government will take into account the “considerations” involved before taking a decision since India needs more competition in aviation.

Indian cos raise ₹1.9 lakh cr via IPOs in FY26

India accounted for 14 per cent of global IPO listings in March 2026

NEW DELHI: Indian companies raised Rs 1.9 lakh crore through more than 360 initial public offerings (IPOs) in FY26, keeping the country among the world's busiest primary markets, though moderating listing gains and subscription levels showed investors becoming more selective.

According to Grant Thornton Bharat's IPO market report released on Monday, fundraising remained strong despite global uncertainty, geopolitical tensions and volatile markets. Investors increasingly favoured companies with stronger fundamentals, better governance,



earnings visibility and disciplined valuations.

Mainboard IPOs reached an all-time high of 109 in FY26, raising around Rs 1.77 lakh crore, compared with 80 issues that mobilised Rs 1.63 lakh crore in FY25. India accounted for 14 per cent of global IPO listings in March 2026, second only to China.

Offer for sale (OFS) transac-

tions accounted for 61 per cent of mainboard IPO proceeds, while fresh issues contributed 39 per cent, indicating a gradual revival in growth-capital raising.

Average IPO oversubscription fell sharply to 39 times in FY26 from 71 times in FY25, reflecting greater scrutiny of valuations, governance and business quality. Average listing-day gains also moderated to 7 per cent from 29 per cent, while listed IPOs recorded an average annual performance of negative 17 per cent.

“In today's IPO market, success is no longer defined by the ability to list, but by the

readiness to operate as a public company with the governance, discipline and credibility to sustain investor confidence well beyond the listing day,” said Karan Marwah, Partner and CFO Advisory Leader, Grant Thornton Bharat. On the SME segment, 258 IPOs raised Rs 12,030 crore in FY26, the highest in the three years reviewed, against Rs 9,900 crore raised through 242 issues in FY25.

The report said the IPO pipeline remains healthy, supported by strong domestic participation, structural growth drivers & expanding investor base.

DLF sells penthouse for ₹271 cr at its luxury housing project ‘The Dahlias’ in Gurugram

The penthouse has a 17,200 sq ft super area and a 10,500 sq ft carpet area

NEW DELHI: Realty major DLF Ltd has sold a penthouse for Rs 271 crore at its upcoming luxury housing project ‘The Dahlias’ in Gurugram, making it one of the costliest property deals on a per-square-foot basis, according to sources.

DLF launched the 17-acre super-luxury project in DLF Phase 5, Gurugram, in October 2024. The project comprises 420 apartments and penthouses.

Sources said DLF sold the penthouse to entrepreneur

CLOSER LOOK

» Sources said DLF sold the penthouse to entrepreneur Manav Sardana, who was associated with Imperial Auto

» The selling price works out to around Rs 1.58 lakh/sq ft on super area & nearly Rs 2.6 lakh/sq ft on carpet area

Manav Sardana, who was associated with Imperial Auto. The unit has a super area of 17,200 sq ft and a carpet area of 10,500 sq ft.

The selling price works out to around Rs 1.58 lakh per sq ft on super area and nearly Rs

2.6 lakh per sq ft on carpet area, sources said. A DLF spokesperson declined to comment.

DLF expects total revenue of more than Rs 40,000 crore from The Dahlias and has already sold over 65 per cent of the units. Apartments are

priced between Rs 100 crore and Rs 170 crore, while penthouses command higher prices.

Luxury housing demand has risen across major cities since the COVID-19 pandemic, with Gurugram and Mumbai witnessing several high-value apartment and penthouse transactions.

DLF's sales bookings fell 94 per cent year-on-year to Rs 657 crore in the June quarter as it did not launch any project. For FY26, bookings declined 5 per cent to Rs 20,143 crore. AGENCIES

ONGC & Shell ink pact to explore deepwater blocks, LNG sourcing

Oil & Natural Gas Corp, Shell Energy India will explore opportunities in OALP Rounds X and XI under broader Samudra Manthan initiative

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Oil and Natural Gas Corp (ONGC) and Shell Energy India Private Ltd have signed a non-binding memorandum of understanding (MoU) to explore joint opportunities in deepwater oil and gas exploration and liquefied natural gas (LNG) sourcing, the state-owned firm said on Monday.

The agreement, signed on August 10, covers potential collaboration across India's energy sector, including joint participation in deepwater and ultra-deepwater offshore blocks offered under the government's Open Acreage Licensing Policy, or OALP, as well as future bidding rounds, ONGC said in a post on X.

ONGC and Shell Energy India will explore opportunities in OALP Rounds X and XI under the broader Samudra Manthan initiative, as well as potential farm-in and farm-out arrangements involving ONGC's existing OALP blocks, the company said.

The memorandum does not commit either company to specific investments or projects and provides a framework for evaluating potential areas of cooperation.



The LNG component could also become significant as India seeks to increase gas consumption while meeting rising energy demand

The agreement with Shell builds on ONGC's recent efforts to bring international expertise into India's deepwater exploration programme. In August 2022, ONGC signed a Heads of Agreement with ExxonMobil to collaborate on deepwater exploration on India's eastern and western coasts.

ONGC has also signed memorandums of understanding with global majors including ExxonMobil and Chevron for deep and ultra-deepwater exploration.

HIGHLIGHTS

» In August 2022, ONGC signed a Heads of Agreement with ExxonMobil to collaborate on deepwater exploration

» ONGC has also signed MoU with global majors including Chevron for deep and ultra-deepwater exploration

» On its collaboration with Shell, ONGC said MoU is to explore potential collaboration across India's energy sector

On its collaboration with Shell, ONGC said the MoU is to explore potential collaboration opportunities across India's energy sector.

The partnership brings together ONGC's position as India's largest oil and gas explorer with Shell's global expertise across upstream exploration and LNG, potentially creating opportunities for cooperation across both domestic exploration and gas supply.

The upstream component comes as India seeks to accelerate exploration of its offshore resources and attract investment and technical expertise into more challenging deepwater and ultra-deepwater acreage.

Under the proposed collaboration, the companies could participate jointly in future offshore licensing rounds and assess opportunities to bring additional partners into existing ONGC blocks through farm-in and farm-out arrangements.

The LNG component could also become significant as India seeks to increase gas consumption while meeting rising energy demand and diversifying its fuel supply.

The collaboration will focus on two key areas of mutual business interest.

"Upstream Oil & Gas: Exploring joint participation in deepwater and ultra-deepwater offshore blocks offered under (currently underway) Open Acreage Licensing Policy (OALP) Rounds X and XI, as well as future bid rounds, under the broader impetus of #SamudraManthan. The two companies will also explore farm-in/farm-out opportunities in ONGC's existing OALP blocks. The MoU sets out a non-binding framework for such collaboration," it said.

Secondly, the two firms

would collaborate on LNG. "Exploring opportunities in #LNG sourcing to support India's transition towards a stronger gas-based economy.

"By bringing together complementary capabilities and global expertise, the collaboration seeks to create new synergies across the energy value chain, supporting deeper exploration, greater energy availability and India's long-term energy security," ONGC said.

The companies will also explore opportunities to collaborate on LNG sourcing, as India seeks to expand the role of natural gas in its energy mix and strengthen the availability of gas supplies.

"Exploring deeper. Collaborating stronger. Powering India's energy future," ONGC said in a post announcing the agreement.

ONGC said the collaboration is intended to create synergies across the energy value chain and support deeper exploration, greater energy availability and India's long-term energy security.

The agreement is part of a broader push by Indian energy companies to secure additional domestic oil and gas resources while expanding access to LNG as the country seeks to build a more gas-based economy.

EXCEEDS REVISED ESTIMATES OF ₹33,837 CR

Asset monetisation, divestment fetch govt ₹45,306 crore in FY26

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government's combined mop-up from disinvestment and asset monetisation stood at Rs 45,306 crore in FY26, exceeding the Revised Estimates (RE), Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said on Monday.

The government had pegged Miscellaneous Capital Receipts, which includes PSU disinvestment and public asset monetisation, at Rs 33,837 crore in the Revised Estimates for FY26.

"Government of India realised an amount of Rs 45,306.05 crore in FY 2025-26, which included Rs 16,885.56 crore from disinvestment and



Rs 28,420.49 crore from Asset Monetisation," Chaudhary said in a written reply to the Lok Sabha.

For the current fiscal, the government has budgeted Rs 80,000 crore under Miscellaneous Capital Receipts.

So far in FY27, it has realised Rs 59,083 crore under Miscellaneous Capital Receipts, which

included about Rs 6,367 crore from asset monetisation.

Besides, Rs 52,716 crore has come from disinvestment through Offer for Sale of Central Bank of India, Coal India Ltd, Life Insurance Corporation (LIC), NHPC, NLC India, General Insurance Corporation of India, Indian Railway Finance Corporation Ltd, and Cochin Shipyard, as well as strategic disinvestment of Indian Medicines Pharmaceuticals Corporation Ltd.

Disinvestment receipts in 2025-26 stood at Rs 16,886 crore, while in 2024-25 it was Rs 10,163 crore. In FY24, FY23 and FY22, it was Rs 16,507 crore, Rs 35,294 crore and Rs 13,534 crore, respectively.

Gold, silver duty hike fetches govt ₹10,463 cr between May 13 & Aug 2

NEW DELHI: The government has collected Rs 10,463 crore as customs duty on gold, silver and platinum between May 13 and August 2, Parliament was informed on Monday.

The import duty on gold and silver had been hiked to 15 per cent, from 6 per cent, and that on platinum to 15.4 per cent from 6.4 per cent, with effect from May 13. Consequential changes were also made to other items, including gold and silver dore, coins, and findings.

In a written reply to a question in the Lok Sabha, Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said the government has collected Rs 10,040 crore as customs duty on gold between May 13 and August 2.

During the period, Rs 328 crore and Rs 95 crore were collected as customs duty on silver and platinum, respectively.

Cumulatively, the total customs duty collection from the

ing gold and silver dore, coins, and findings.

In a written reply to a question in the Lok Sabha, Minister of State for Finance Pankaj Chaudhary said the government has collected Rs 10,040 crore as customs duty on gold between May 13 and August 2.

During the period, Rs 328 crore and Rs 95 crore were collected as customs duty on silver and platinum, respectively.

Cumulatively, the total customs duty collection from the

three precious metals during the period stood at Rs 10,463 crore. Chaudhary further said that between May 13 and June 30, 161 kg of smuggled gold were seized and 116 persons were arrested.

On May 13, the government had hiked import duty on gold, silver and platinum to check discretionary imports and prioritise forex for essential imports like crude oil, fertilisers, industrial raw materials and capital goods. PFI

Vodafone Idea Q1 loss narrows to ₹3,754 crore



NEW DELHI: Debt-ridden telecom firm Vodafone Idea on Monday reported a narrowing of loss to Rs 3,754 crore in the April-June quarter of the current fiscal mainly on account of relaxation given by the government on dues, a company filing said.

The company had posted a net loss of Rs 6,611 crore in the same period a year ago.

Revenue from operations grew 6 per cent year-on-year to Rs 11,689 crore during the quarter under review from Rs 11,023 crore in the same period of FY2025-26.

The subscriber base of the company during the June quarter declined by around 2 per cent to 19.31 crore from 19.77 crore in the same quarter a year ago.

However, the company posted a 10.2 per cent rise in the customer ARPU (average revenue per user) to Rs 195 in April-June quarter of FY2026-27, compared to Rs 177 in same period of previous financial year. PFI

BSE to enter Nifty 50, Wipro to exit in Sept rejig

MUMBAI: BSE Ltd will enter the benchmark Nifty 50 index, replacing IT major Wipro Ltd as part of NSE Indices Ltd's latest semi-annual review.

The changes will take effect from September 30, 2026, after the close of trading on September 29, NSE Indices said in a release on Monday. The reshuffle was approved by its Index Maintenance Sub-Committee (Equity).

BSE recorded an average free-float market capitalisation of Rs 1,40,879 crore during the six-month review period, compared with Rs 55,930 crore for Wipro.

BSE qualified for inclusion as its average free-float market capitalisation was at least 1.5 times that of the smallest Nifty 50 constituent.

TVS Motor Company and Divi's Laboratories were the

next two eligible companies, with average free-float market capitalisations of Rs 84,566 crore and Rs 82,930 crore, respectively. However, neither met the required threshold for inclusion.

The BSE-Wipro replacement will also apply to the Nifty50 Equal Weight index.

Following its exit from the Nifty 50, Wipro will enter the Nifty Next 50. Hitachi Energy India, Polycab India, Vedanta Aluminium Metal and Vodafone Idea will also be added to the index, while Indian Hotels, Lodha Developers, REC, Shree Cement and United Spirits will exit.

Similar changes will be made to the Nifty 100, with BSE and the four other companies entering, while the five outgoing Nifty Next 50 constituents will be removed. AGENCIES

Mutual fund schemes with negative returns nearly triple in FY26: SEBI

NEW DELHI: Mutual fund performance weakened significantly in FY26, with the number of schemes reporting negative annual returns nearly tripling to 731 from 243 in the previous financial year, according to the SEBI's annual report for 2025-26.

The number of schemes delivering returns of more than 5 per cent declined to 737 in FY26 from 1,156 in FY25, reflecting a more subdued market environment.

Schemes reporting returns of -10 per cent or lower rose more than threefold to 93 from 30, while those in the -10 per cent to -5 per cent category increased to 146 from 41. The largest rise was recorded among



schemes returning between -5 per cent and 0 per cent, with their number increasing to 492 from 172.

Meanwhile, schemes generating positive returns of 0-5 per cent increased to 373 from 218. However, the number delivering 5-10 per cent returns fell to 539 from 852, while schemes generating more than 10 per cent returns declined to 198 from 304.

"The distribution of mutual

fund schemes reflected subdued market performance during 2025-26," SEBI said.

The number of new mutual fund schemes remained largely unchanged at 246 in FY26, compared with 247 in FY25. Of these, 244 were open-ended and two were close-ended schemes.

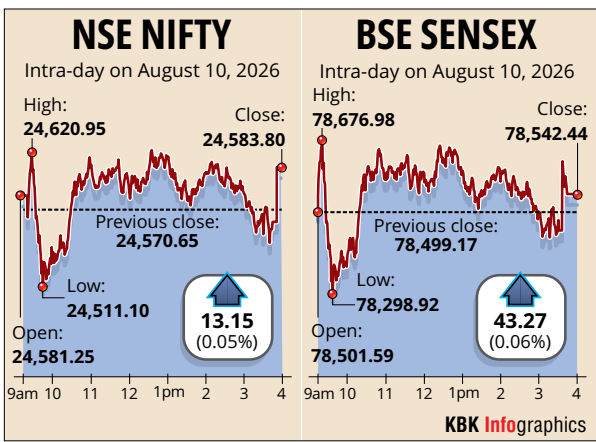
Debt-oriented fund launches rose to 16 from 10, while equity-oriented launches fell to 63 from 70. Hybrid fund launches increased to 15 from 12. Domestic fund of funds launches rose sharply to 49 from 14. Despite weaker returns, the mutual fund industry's investor base expanded 13.2 per cent to 6.1 crore unique investors in FY26 from 5.4 crore a year earlier. AGENCIES

scale, complements our strong pipeline of contracted capacity, and meaningfully brings forward the growth of the platform," RPSG Vice Chairman Shashwat Goenka said.

The enterprise value excludes an estimated contingent payment of Rs 230 crore linked to additional realisation from a change-in-law claim.

The final consideration will be adjusted for debt, cash & other items. The transaction is expected to close before October 31, 2026. AGENCIES

Mkts end marginally higher amid crude oil spike



cent to USD 84.47 per barrel.

The BSE MidCap Select index went up 0.22 per cent and SmallCap Select index eked out a marginal gain of 0.16 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, realty jumped 1.60 per cent, consumer durables (1.21 per cent), capital goods (0.47 per cent), industrials (0.41 per cent) focused IT (0.34 per cent) and

IT (0.22 per cent).

PSU Bank declined 1.30 per cent, Housing Finance (0.59 per cent), MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (0.55 per cent), MidSmall Private Banks (0.36 per cent).

FII's bought equities worth Rs 480.24 crore on Friday, according to exchange data.

In Asian markets, South

Day traders to boycott trading on Aug 12 against newly launched CAS

NEW DELHI: Day traders have launched an online campaign calling for a one-day boycott of stock market trading on August 12, protesting the recently introduced Closing Auction Session (CAS), high taxes and frequent regulatory changes.

Several posts on social media urged traders to stay away from the markets for a day. One trader on X, who has nearly 1.5 lakh followers, posted, "No trade day on Aug 12. Against STT (securities transaction tax). Against CAS." Another post described the move as a protest against regulations and rising taxes affecting retail traders.

Traders have alleged that

CAS has resulted in significant differences between the Nifty and Sensex and discrepancies in the closing prices of some stocks, causing losses for market participants.

CAS was introduced to determine the closing prices of around 200 stocks that are also traded in the derivatives segment. Earlier, closing prices in the equity cash segment were based on the Volume Weighted Average Price (VWAP) of trades executed during the final 30 minutes of continuous trading.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) said global passive funds had reported that Indian equities experienced signifi-

Among sectoral indices, realty jumped 1.60%, consumer durables (1.21%), capital goods (0.47%), industrials (0.41%) focused IT (0.34%) and IT (0.22%)

Korea's KOSPI, Japan's Nikkei 225 index, Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended higher. Markets in Europe were trading on a mixed note. US markets ended in positive territory on Friday.

On Friday, the Sensex dropped 455.59 points, or 0.58 per cent, to settle at 78,499.17. The Nifty dipped 65.35 points, or 0.27 per cent, to end at 24,570.65. PFI

Rupee falls 13 paise to 95.30 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee declined by 13 paise to settle at 95.30 against the US dollar on Monday amid a firm greenback and a rise in global crude oil prices.

Lack of any breakthrough in talks in West Asia put further pressure on the local unit, while FII inflows provided some support, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.18 and traded in a narrow range of 95.18-95.32 during the day.

The local unit settled at 95.30, down 13 paise from its previous close of 95.17 on Friday.

"The rupee declined on Monday on uncertainty over a deal between the US and Iran and overnight surge in crude oil prices. US dollar strengthened from lower levels. However, positive domestic markets cushioned the downside," Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

"Traders may remain cautious ahead of the US inflation data this week. USDINR spot price is expected to trade in a range of Rs 95-95.60," he said.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the dollar's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.66, up 0.13 per cent.

The RBI data released on Friday showed that the country's forex reserves jumped by \$10.512 billion to \$692.866 billion during the week ended July 31. PFI

CESC arm Purvah Green to acquire ReNew Solar Power's 1.4 GW portfolio for ₹4,859 cr

It will raise Purvah's operational renewable energy capacity to over 1.8 GWp

NEW DELHI: CESC subsidiary Purvah Green Power Private Limited will acquire about 1.4 GWp of operational renewable energy capacity from ReNew Solar Power Pvt Ltd for an enterprise value of Rs 4,859 crore, according to a stock exchange filing on Monday.

Purvah has signed a share purchase agreement to acquire 100 per cent ownership of six ReNew subsidiaries holding a combined installed capacity of 1,411.48 MWp.



Shashwat Goenka, Vice chairman, RPSG

The acquisition will take Purvah's operational renewable capacity to more than 1.8 GWp and its overall portfolio

to 4.8 GWp, including around 3 GWp of contracted or tied-up projects at various stages of construction.

Over 90 per cent of the acquired capacity is contracted with the Solar Energy Corporation of India under 25-year power purchase agreements, while the remaining capacity is tied up with Karnataka power distribution companies.

"The acquisition marks a significant acceleration of our renewable energy journey. It gives us immediate operating

scale, complements our strong pipeline of contracted capacity, and meaningfully brings forward the growth of the platform," RPSG Vice Chairman Shashwat Goenka said.

The enterprise value excludes an estimated contingent payment of Rs 230 crore linked to additional realisation from a change-in-law claim.

The final consideration will be adjusted for debt, cash & other items. The transaction is expected to close before October 31, 2026. AGENCIES

FAIFA welcomes relief for Tobacco growers, urges calibrated crop cuts to protect legitimate growers

NEW DELHI: The Federation of All India Farmer Associations (FAIFA) on Monday welcomed initiatives by the Central and Andhra Pradesh governments to provide relief to tobacco growers facing financial stress due to weak global demand and accumulation of unsold stocks.

The association said growers, particularly in Andhra Pradesh, are also facing pressure from high taxation on the legal domestic industry and tax-arbitrage-driven smuggling and illicit trade, which have weakened legitimate demand.

FAIFA, however, expressed concern over the Tobacco Board's decision to reduce the

authorised Flue-Cured Virginia (FCV) tobacco crop size by 43 per cent for the upcoming season. While acknowledging the need to address the demand-supply imbalance, it said such a steep reduction could add to farmers' financial burden amid weak price realisation and rising debt.

The association noted that costs related to curing barns, labour and farm infrastructure would not decline proportionately with lower crop allocations. It also said many FCV-growing regions have limited alternatives due to their agro-climatic conditions.

PS Murali Babu, President,

FAIFA, said, "The decision to reduce the crop is rooted in prevailing market realities, and farmers understand the need to restore demand and supply balance.

However, successful implementation requires a comprehensive support framework that protects farmer incomes while strengthening exports, addressing illicit trade and creating viable long-term opportunities. The objective should not simply be producing less tobacco but producing the right quantity, for the right markets, at remunerative prices."

FAIFA called for stronger export promotion, farmer sup-

port comparable with major tobacco-producing countries and sustained action against illicit trade.

It recommended a calibrated approach involving farmer organisations, better communication of market demand before planting, satellite-based crop monitoring, improved field verification and incentives for voluntary compliance.

The association said sustained coordination among the Tobacco Board, farmers, exporters and manufacturers would be crucial to restore confidence and ensure the long-term sustainability of the FCV tobacco sector. MPOST

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Rakesh Kumar Sachdeva** Authorised Signatory/Prop/Partner New Punjab Motors & Tractor Works at E-Villa Central Park-I Gurugram Golf Course Road Sector 42, Haryana 1220022, office at C-17A SSI Industrial Area, Jahangirpuri, New Delhi 110033 also at B-80 Wazirpur, Industrial Area, Delhi 110052 has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 2037/2023 U/s 138 NI ACT, PS Paschim Vihar East, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Rakesh Kumar Sachdeva** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rakesh Kumar Sachdeva** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Rakesh Kumar Sachdeva** in **FIR No. 2037/2023 U/s 138 NI ACT, PS Paschim Vihar East, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **21.09.2026**.

By order
Sh. Anshul Singhal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04
Room No. 268
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/10989/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2)(ii) Cr.P.C)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **NEERAJ VERMA S/o Ashok Kumar Verma R/o Lambe Bazar, Dankaur, Gautambudh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-203201** *also at: D-1, Kadar Natu Marg, Gali No. 10, Anand Parbat Industrial Area, Near Axis Bank, New Delhi; and also at: AWHO Society, 4R Flat No. 601, Pari Chowk, Greater Noida-201310* has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No./Ct. Case No. 751/2020, PS Karol Bagh, Central Distt. New Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **NEERAJ VERMA** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **NEERAJ VERMA** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **ADITYA SETIA** of **FIR No./Ct. Case No. 751/2020, PS Karol Bagh, Central Distt. New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **11.09.2026 at 10:00 AM**.

By Order
Ms. Aradhana
JMFC (N.I. Act)-09,
Dentrall Distt., Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/11047/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

Regd. Office: ICICI Bank Limited, Landmark, Race Course Circle, Vadodara- 390007, Corporate Office: ICICI Bank Towers, Bandra-Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai- 400051, Branch Office: ICICI Bank Ltd., Shal Tower, Plot No. 23, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, Delhi 110005

Annexure 54
Notice for Disclosure of Legal Heirs of Deceased Borrower
PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that Overdraft 033105004176 (Credit facility) was granted M/S. HARI OM ENTERPRISES, SARLA DEVI, AKHIL AGGARWAL, DIPTÉE AGGARWAL, along with the deceased MR. AKHIL AGGARWAL by ICICI Bank Ltd. (The Bank).

We would like to inform you that the demise of MR.AKHIL AGGARWAL has come to our knowledge during field visits conducted by the Bank officials and by telephonic communications on the registered contact numbers. In this regard, letter dated AUGUST 06,2026 was previously sent to the registered addresses of the Borrowers and the deceased MR.AKHIL AGGARWAL, for providing information about the Legal Heirs of the deceased Borrower.

Therefore, this Notice is hereby given for sharing details of the Legal Heirs of the deceased MR. AKHIL AGGARWAL with supporting documents for updating the Bank's records, within 15 days of publication of this Notice.

You may submit the above-mentioned details to Mr. SHIVAM MISHRA by visiting ICICI BANK LTD, THIRD FLOOR SECTOR 14 KOUSHAMBHI NEAR SEEMNAT VIHARA, UTTAR PRADESH GHAZIABAD - 201010
MOBILE NO.:8657910179
Date : August 11, 2026
Place : North Delhi & Delhi

SD Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd,

VANI COMMERCIALS LIMITED

CIN: L74899DL1988PLC106425

Regd. office : 201, 2nd floor, BMC House, N Block, Near Maruti Suzuki Arena, Connaught Place, Delhi -110001
PH: +91- 9560066230 | Website: www.vanicommercials.com | Email ID: info@vanicommercials.com

EXTRACT OF UNAUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER ENDED 30TH JUNE, 2026

Particulars	STANDALONE				CONSOLIDATED			
	(Rs. In Lakhs)				(Rs. In Lakhs)			
	3 Months ended	Preceding 3 Months ended	Corresponding 3 Months ended (Previous Year)	Year ended (Current Year)	3 Months ended	Preceding 3 Months ended	Corresponding 3 Months ended (Previous Year)	Year ended (Current Year)
	30.06.2026 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)	30.06.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)	30.06.2026 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)	30.06.2025 (Unaudited)	31.03.2026 (Audited)
Total income from operations (net)	157.77	155.00	131.14	570.00	157.77	155.00	131.14	570.36
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	24.86	8.72	19.76	65.18	25.37	8.72	19.76	65.18
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	24.86	8.72	19.76	65.18	25.37	8.72	19.76	65.18
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	24.86	8.72	19.76	35.59	25.37	8.72	19.76	35.59
Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit/(Loss)] for the period (after tax) and other comprehensive Income (after tax)	24.86	8.72	19.76	35.59	25.37	8.72	19.76	35.59
Equity Share Capital (Paid-Up)	2,940.73	2,940.73	1,174.06	2,940.73	2,941.24	2,940.73	1,174.06	2,940.73
Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve) as shown in the Audited Balance Sheet of the previous year								
Earnings Per Share (of Rs. 10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations)								
1. Basic:	0.08	0.03	0.17	0.12	0.09	0.03	0.17	0.12
2. Diluted:	0.08	0.03	0.17	0.12	0.09	0.03	0.17	0.12

*Paid up Equity Share Capital & Earning Per Share provided above relates only to Vani Commercials Limited.

NOTES:
1 These Unaudited Financial Results of the Company have been prepared in accordance with the Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS) as prescribed under Section 133 of the Companies Act 2013 read with Rule 3 of the Companies (Indian Accounting Standard) Rules, 2015.
2 The above unaudited financial results for the quarter ended 30th June, 2026 have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors of the Company at their respective meetings held on 8th August, 2026. These results have been subjected to limited review by the Statutory Auditors of the Company under Regulation 33 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.
3 Previous year's/period's figures have been regrouped / rearranged, wherever required
4 The Unaudited Financial Results of the Company for the Quarter ended on 30th June, 2026 are also available on website of the Company (www.vanicommercials.com) and on the website of BSE Limited (www.bseindia.com)
5 The Limited review as required under Regulation 33 of SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulation, 2015 has been completed and related report does not have any impact on above results and notes for the Quarter ended 30th June, 2026 which need to be explained.

For Vani Commercials Limited
Sd/-
Vishal Abrol
Managing Director
DIN: 06938389

Date: 8th August, 2026
Place: New Delhi

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-OPEN TENDER NOTICE

NO. S&T/SEE/OT/26-27/26 Date: 04.08.2026

The DRM (S&T & Telecom)/SEE for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open E-Tenders for the following works. The last date of online E-tendering is **28.08.2026 upto 12:00 hrs.** All information and tender documents related to E-tender is available on website - www.ireps.gov.in.
Sl. No.: 1, E-Tender No: S&T/SEE/OT/26-27/26, Name of Work: Strengthening & Augmentation of Sig. Assets at LC gates for reliability improvement, enhancing Safety & punctuality in Train operations in SEE Div. **Approx Cost (In Rs.): 4,91,30,035.09, Earnest Money (In Rs.): 9,82,600.00, Cost of Tender Document (In Rs.) (Non-refundable):0.00, Completion period: 09 (Nine) Months from date of issue of LOA.**

The above tender notice is available on website www.ireps.gov.in. Uploading date **04.08.2026**

RIGHT OF RAILWAY TO DEAL WITH TENDER: Railway Administration reserves the right to postpone /modify or to cancel any one or all the tenders without assigning any reasons.

Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer
E.C. Railway Sonpur
PR/0692/SEE/S&T/26-27/40

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA

PUBLIC WORK DEPARTMENT

INVITATION FOR TENDER

Tender Notice No. 29 Year 2026-27

Sr No.	Name of wok	Estimated Cost
1.	Repair Renovation of Integrated Child Development Service Scheme, Maharashtra State, Belapur, Navi Mumbai (Women and Child Development Department, Maharashtra State)	1,96,20,122.00

1. Period of E-tenders :- Date. 13-8-2026 to Date. 24-8-2026

2. Pre bid conference Date and Place :- Date. 17-8-2026 at 02.10 hrs. the office of the Superintending Engineer Thane (PW) Circle, Thane.

3. Date of Opening (If Possible) :- Date. 25-8-2026 at 14.00 hrs. the office of the Superintending Engineer Thane (PW) Circle, Thane

1. Tender form Condition of Contract Specification and Contract drawing can be downloaded from e-tendering portal of public work Department of Maharashtra i.e. <https://mahatenders.gov.in>

2. Tender Notice can be seen also on website <https://mahatenders.gov.in&www.Mahapwd.com>

No./TD/Tender/7627
Office of the Executive Engineer
P.W. Division No.1 Thane
Date - 06/08/2026.

Executive Engineer
P.W. Division No.1 Thane
Dgipr/2026-27/2207

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Deepak @Sonu** S/o Boran Singh R/o H. No. 12/69 Trilokpuri, Delhi Kalyanpuri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 20692/2020 U/s 379 IPC, PS Mandawali, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Deepak @Sonu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Deepak @Sonu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Deepak @Sonu** in **FIR No. 20692/2020 U/s 379 IPC, PS Mandawali, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.09.2026**.

By order
Sh. Sachin
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
East District, Court No. 16
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/10509/ED/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Surender Yadav S/o Sh. Ayodhya Yadav R/o Gali No. 5, Janta Vihar, Mukundpur, Delhi** has committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No./CC No. 380/2024 U/s 12/9/55 Delhi Gambling Act, PS Model Town, Distt. North-East, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Surender Yadav** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Surender Yadav** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation are hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Surender Yadav** of **FIR No./CC No. 380/2024 U/s 12/9/55 Delhi Gambling Act, PS Model Town, Distt. North-East, Delhi** are required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **10.09.2026 at 10:00 AM**.

By Order
Sh. Aakash Sharma
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Court No. 213, Distt. North
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/11094/NWD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Gulshan @Kalu** S/o Kashmiri Lal R/o H. No. A-14, Gali No.1, South Ganesh Nagar, Mandawali has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 471/2020, PS Mandawali, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Gulshan @Kalu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Gulshan @Kalu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Gulshan @Kalu** in **FIR No. 471/2020, PS Mandawali, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **13.10.2026**.

By order
Sh. Sachin
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
East District, Court No. 16
Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/11005/ED/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No: 18-Elect/G/PRYJ/2627 Dated: 07.08.2026

E-Tender Notice

Senior Divl. Electrical Engineer/Gen/N. C. Rly/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following e- Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to 15.00 hrs. on 31.08.2026
The details of the tenders are as under:-

SN.: 1	TN.: ELG-43-2627	Cost of work (in ₹): ₹ 76.94,883.10
Name of work: Running contract for Repairing, Replacement of spare parts of submersible motor/pumps and Rewinding of submersible motor (01 phase & 03 phase) under SSE/PL/CNB depot (ex KBN to ETW) for two years.		
Bid Security(in ₹): ₹ 1,53,900.00	Duration of completion: 24 Month	
SN.: 2	TN.: ELG-44-2627	Cost of work (in ₹): ₹ 2,23,82,791.00
Name of work: Provision of power point wiring arrangements in type II and III Staff Qtrs. over Prayagraj division. (Phase-I).		
Bid Security(in ₹): ₹ 4,47,700.00	Duration of completion: 06 Month	
SN.: 3	TN.: ELG-45-2627	Cost of work (in ₹): ₹ 59.22,954.05
Name of work: Electrical work in connection with the work of "Etawah-Construction of 06 units, Type-II staff in lieu of abandoned qtrs. at Etawah under ADEN/ETW.". Electrical work in connection with the work of Mainpur: Raising of Platform no. 2/3 up to high level for recruitment of shortfall in Minimum Essential Amenities (MEA) at MNQ under SKB-FBD section. Electrical work in connection with the work of "Provision of all balance facilities for divyangjan at SB, MNR, EKL & JGR under Ambiapur- Tundla section,".		
Bid Security(in ₹): ₹ 1,18,500.00	Duration of completion: 06 Month	
SN.: 4	Tender No.: ELG-46-2627	Cost of work (in ₹): ₹ 62.02,972.30
Name of work: Electrical work in connection with the work of "AAP-SB: Provision of water supply arrangement with submersible pump at way side colony under ADEN/ETW.". Electrical work in connection with the work of "Firozabad-Construction of underground water tank connected with JEDDAH JHAL Parityajana at Firozabad Platform.". Electrical work in connection with the work of "Construction work of RPF POST PHD Office."		
Bid Security(in ₹): ₹ 1,24,100.00	Duration of completion: 06 Month	
SN.: 5	Tender No.: ELG-47-2627	Cost of work (in ₹): ₹ 74.89,953.28
Name of work: Electrical work in connection with Construction of 20 bed RPF barrack in Shikohabad. Electrical work in connection with the work of "PRYJ: Raising of Platform up to Raising of Platform up to high level for recruitment of shortfall in MEAT HRS (PF No. 283) & BRN (PF No. 18.2) Stations. Electrical works in connection with "BLC monitoring centre at Khurja". Electrical works in connection with "BLC monitoring centre at Aligarh".		
Bid Security(in ₹): ₹ 1,49,800.00	Duration of completion: 06 Month	
Tender Opening Date: 31.08.2026. 15:00 Hrs.		
Note: - 1. The complete information along with tender document of above e-Tender is available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs. on the due date of tender opening. 1835/26(AK)		
f North central railways ✉ @CPRONCR 🌐 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in		

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.: - 6120260207 Date : 07.08.2026

E- Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/ North Central Railway/ Prayagraj, tor and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-TENDERS on prescribed form for the following work up to 13.30 hrs. on 02.09.2026. The details of the Tender are as under:-

S.N.: 1	Tender No.: 133, Name of Work: Flash butt welding of rail on various loop lines and other lines in the jurisdiction of Sr. DEN/IV/PRYJ	Approx. Cost of work (₹) : ₹ 3,33,94,863.37	Bid Security (₹) : ₹ 6,67,900.00
Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Any P. Way work involving weld renewal work with mobile flash butt welding plant.			
S.N.: 2	Tender No.: 134, Name of Work: Provision of Rain water harvesting in TDL- GZB section under Sr. DEN/IV/PRYJ.	Approx. Cost of work (₹) : ₹ 54,98,578.17	Bid Security (₹) : ₹ 1,10,000.00
Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Any Civil Engineering Work.			
S.N.: 3	Tender No.: 135, Name of Work: Supply of welding portions in the section of Sr. ADEN/TDL	Approx. Cost of work (₹) : ₹ 1,33,48,076.49	Bid Security (₹) : ₹ 2,67,000.00
Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Supply of 52 Kg/60 Kg Alunino Temic welding portion from RDSO approved firm only.			
S.N.: 4	Tender No.: 136, Name of Work: TRR(P) Work in TDL-GZB Section Under Sr. DEN/IV/PRYJ	Approx. Cost of work (₹) : ₹ 3,64,76,679.93	Bid Security (₹) : ₹ 7,29,500.00
Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Any P. Way work.			
Completion Period: For S.N. 1, 3 & 4:- 12 months, and S.N. 2:- 8 months.			
Date Opening of tender : For S.N. 1 to 4:- 02.09.2026			
Note: (1) E-Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenderers. (2) The complete information along with tender document of above E-TENDER is available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 13:30hrs. on the due date of tender opening i.e., 02.09.2026. (3) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. (4) The tenderers shall submit a copy of certificate as given in tender document in standard format, without which their tender may not be considered and shall be summarily rejected. (5) In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. (6) The tenderer has to submit necessary documents in compliance of clause 10 to 18 (Part-I) of GCC April 2022 mandatorily, otherwise offer will be considered as incomplete offer and accordingly shall not be considered. 1842/26 (MG)			
f North central railways ✉ @CPRONCR 🌐 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in			

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Namely: **Shatrughan Singh Bhadaryia, S/o.Late Sh. Raghuraj Singh, Prop.of/M/s. Agam Power Coating Industries At R/o: Village-Barola, Post-Birari, P.S.-Ekidil, Tehsil-Bhartana, Mauza Bilrapur, District - Etawah, Uttar Pradesh, Mobile No.9058363307 Also at: H.No.41/1B, Gali No.6, Jwala Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide **CC No.13418/2017 U/S 138 NI Act** registered at **P.S Kamla Market, Central District, Delhi** and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest there upon issued stating that the said **Shatrughan Singh Bhadaryia** could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Shatrughan Singh Bhadaryia** is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Shatrughan Singh Bhadaryia**, accused of **CC No.13418/2017 U/S 138 NI Act, P.S Kamla Market, Central District, Delhi** is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.09.2026 at 10.00 AM**.

By Order, **Sh. Arjun Kirar**
DP/11074/CD/2026 Judicial Magistrate First Class-05-NI Act
(Court Matter) Room No.2, Central DistrictTis Hazari Court, Delhi

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. 230-Elect/TRD/PRYJ/E-Tender Notice/2026/651 Date: 07.08.2026

E-TENDE NOTICE

Sr. Divl. Electrical Engineer/TRD/North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of President of India, invite the following E-Tender, the details of the tenders are as under:-

T. No.: 230-TRD-WC-1040-2026	Advertised value: Rs. 96.51,457.45
Description of work: 25kV OHE Modification work due to Provision of FOB at Faizullapur (FYZ) station and Raising of Platform no. 1 & 2 to high level at Sirsaul (SSL) station in Prayagraj Division.	
Bid Security: Rs. 1,93,000.00	Completion Period: 18 Months
Bidding system: Single Packet Tender Closing date & Time: 31.08.2026 & 14:00 hrs.	
Tender Opening date & Time: 31.08.2026 & 15:00 hrs.	
Note:- 1. The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders shall be available on website www.ireps.gov.in 21 days prior to the date of opening of the tender. 2. Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificate. 3. In case of any difficulty helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. 1840/26(K)	
f North central railways 🌐 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in ✉ @CPRONCR	

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. AGC-EL-C-01R2-2025-26 Date: 07.08.2026

E-Tender Notice

Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer (Const.), North Central Railway, Agra for and behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on line only (E-Tendering) for the following works.

Tender No. AGC-EL-C-01R2-2025-26	Bid Security: As per IREPS/-
Name of work with its location: Modification/Shifting of 33KV, 11 KV, 440 Volt Electrical Power Line Over Head Crossing of State Electricity Board by Under Ground XLPE Cable at Various Location between BARI- SIRMUTTRA (Phase-II) Section in Connection with the work of Gauge Conversion from N.G. to B.G. between DHO-SRMT Section of Agra Division of North Central Railway	
Approx. Cost of the work: ₹ 1,91,50,769.52/-	
Completion Period: 12 Months from the date of issue of acceptance letter including monsoon period.	
Tender closing date & time: 31.08.2026 upto 15.00 hrs.	
Validity of offer: 60 days from the date of tender opening.	
Tenderers can only submit their offer through web portal www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs on 31.08.2026. For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in . 1843/26(AK)	
f North central railways ✉ @CPRONCR 🌐 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in	

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. AGC/TRD/T/2026/23 Date: 07.08.2026

E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE

Sr. DEE/TRD/Agra for & on behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on-line only (e-Tendering) for the following work.

Tender No.: AGC/TRD/202623	Approximate Cost: Rs. 52.08,626/-
Name of Work: Modification in OHE due to Provision of 05 nos. of Lifts at RKM & FTS stations to recoup divyangjans facility in Agra Division	
Earnest Money: Rs. 1.04,200/-	Period of Completion: 12 months
1. For full details and submission of the bid please see the Indian Railway website www.ireps.gov.in . 2. Tender can only be submitted through web portal "www.ireps.gov.in" up to 15:30 Hrs. on date 31.08.2026. 1832/26(K)	
f North central railways 🌐 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in ✉ @CPRONCR	

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Letter No:- DRM/C/AGRA/PAY & USE/POLICY/2018 Dated:- 07.08.2026

E-Auction Notice

On Behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per categories given as under:-

Category: Normal Pay & Use	Auction Catalogue No. : PnU-AGRA-12
Asset Details	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at Achhnera Jn. (IRFC) Railway Station.	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at Rupbas RBS (IRFC) Railway Station..	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at GVH (IRFC) Railway Station.	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis JAB (IRFC) Railway Station.	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at DEEG (IRFC) Railway Station.	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at FTS (IRFC) Railway Station	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at KLB (IRFC) Railway Station.	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at BINR (IRFC) Railway Station.	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at RAH (IRFC) Railway Station.	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at VRBD (IRFC) Railway Station.	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at RKM (IRFC) Railway Station.	
Manning of Normal Pay & Use Toilet on Operation and Maintenance (O&M) basis at CHJ (IRFC) Railway Station.	
E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date: 24.08.2026 Time 15:00	
E-Auction End Date and Time: 24.08.2026 Time 17:20	
Note:- Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. 1827/26(AK)	
f North central railways ✉ @CPRONCR 🌐 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in	

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. CEN-2026-27-09 E- Tender Notice Date : 05.08.2026

E- Tender Notice

The Dy. Chief Engineer/Const./North Central Railway/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to 15.00 hrs. on 28.08.2026. The details of the tenders are as under:-

Tender No.: CEN-2026-27-09. **Name of work:** Construction NEW E/I building other service building, Tower wagon shed, platform, extension of FOB/ramp, staff quarters etc. Supply, transportation and leading of Ballast, Track linking works, Transportation of P. Way materials, AT and FB welding & other ancillary misc. works for Manikpur Station under the jurisdiction of DY. CE/CPRYJ. In connection with MKP-IDGJ 3rd line project.

Approx. cost of work (₹) : ₹ 35.37 Cr. (approx.)	Bid Security (₹) : ₹ 70.73,300/-
Completion period: 15 Months Tender Closing Date & Time: 28.08.2026, 15:00 hrs	
Date of Opening of tender : 28.08.2026, 15:30 hrs.	
Type of tendering : Open (Two Packet System)	
Note: (1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 15.00 hrs on the due date of tender opening i.e. 28.08.2026. (2) Bids other than in the form of E-bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. (3) The Bid Security shall be deposited either in cash through e-payment gateway or submitted as Bank Guarantee bond from a scheduled commercial bank of India or as mentioned in tender document. The Bank Guarantee bond shall be as per format in favour of FA & CAO/CINCR/PRYJ as given in Tender Document and shall be valid for a period of 90 days beyond the bid validity period. (4) Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendor shall be straight way ignored and shall not be considered. (5) Joint Venture (JV)/Consortiums/MOUs shall be considered for the tender having cost more than 10 Cr. (6) Documents being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. (7) The tenderers shall submit a certificate as given in tender document in standard format for all items without which their tender may not be considered and shall be summarily rejected. (8) Each page of the copy of documents/certificates in support of credentials, submitted by the tenderer, shall be self-attested/digitally signed by the tenderer or authorized representative of the tendering firm. Self-attestation shall include signature, stamp and	

New and improved Sarfaraz

Lighter by 17kg, gruelling sessions in Kashmir, Sarfaraz ready for SL challenge

NEW DELHI: A few days before he was recalled to India's Test squad, Sarfaraz Khan had declared on social media that, "I may not fit in, but I'll fight with everything I've got." It was a message of resolve but one that was acutely aware of the probabilities at that point.

But as luck would have it, his resolve won.

An injury to Sai Sudharshan opened up the window of opportunity which Sarfaraz had been waiting for the past two years. He was included for the two-match away Test series against Sri Lanka beginning on August 15.

The recall could not have come at a more opportune time for the Mumbaier, having done all that he could to "fit in", including shedding 17kg in the past year and a half.

For someone, who has fought the perception of being a bit more burly for international cricket despite scoring a marathon triple hundred in Ranji Trophy, Sarfaraz now sports a sharper look, something that has certainly elevated his T20 game.

Add to it, hours and hours spent at the Sher-e-Kashmir Stadium in Kashmir to sharpen his skills because seasonal rains made it impossible to have regular training in Mumbai.



Sarfaraz Khan is an exceptional player of the spin bowling

PTI

The comeback, therefore, is one to savour as being dropped after four failures against New Zealand, back in 2024, was hard to process.

It was a series in which everyone failed but the axe fell only on the 28-year-old.

He then went to England and scored 92 for India A in an unofficial Test against England Lions apart from a century in an intra-squad game (India vs India A) at Beckenham.

But the comeback still

remained a distant dream until India's meek surrender to South Africa at home set the alarm bells ringing.

If sources are to be believed, the team management had, back then, enquired about Sarfaraz ahead of the second Test in Guwahati but the selection committee wasn't ready to take him back into the fold.

However, with Sudharshan's right big-toe impact injury still far from healed, the national selection committee had three

options -- Rituraj Gaikwad, who has a first-class career average in mid 40s, greenhorn Shaikh Rasheed who is more of a No. 3.

The third and most logical option had to be Sarfaraz, who is probably the best player of spin bowling apart from skipper Shubman Gill and Rishabh Pant in this current set-up.

Also with Dhruv Jurel not really coming good against spinners for some time now (at least when he is playing for the

The recall could not have come at a more opportune time for the Mumbaier, having done all that he could to "fit in"

senior national team), one can't be sure that the Uttar Pradesh man will play as a pure batter against the island nation when the first Test starts in Galle on August 15.

Sarfaraz way better than Jurel

Jurel came to Sri Lanka last month as the skipper of the India A team and scored a big hundred and a fifty in the two 'A' Tests but in the practice game that ended on Sunday, he was out cheaply defending against an off-spinner.

It is now well documented that Jurel has problems playing off-spinners. South Africa's Simon Harmer got him thrice in four innings during the series against the Proteas.

In case of Sarfaraz, he has better range of strokes, including the conventional and reverse sweep, which he can play in-front and behind the square.

AGENCIES

NEW DELHI: The organisers of the upcoming BWF World Championships in India have taken extensive steps to upgrade the venue, the Indira Gandhi Stadium, to avoid the embarrassment that rocked the India Open earlier this year.

The Badminton Association of India (BAI) and the Sports Authority of India (SAI) -- the venue's owner -- learnt their lesson the hard way. During the India Open in January, pigeons twice halted a second-round match between HS Prannoy and Loh Kean Yew. The subsequent complaints regarding hygiene and Delhi's smog left the BAI in a difficult position.

With the BWF World Championships returning to India after 17 years, the organisers are leaving no stone unturned to avoid further controversies. They have put anti-bird measures in place and even roped in monkey whispermasters to host the world-class event from August 17 to 23.

The vents have been sealed, wooden doors have been replaced with a double-door entry system, and an automatic outer door has been added ahead of the regular ones. Additionally, a non-toxic gel sourced from the US has been applied around the stadium's



People walk past empty spectator stands inside the stadium

PTI

um's ducting to keep birds and insects away, while portable machines that mimic predatory bird calls have been installed as a final layer of defence.

"The January event, the India Open, we had our job cut out... so we had to improve it and we were given this task. We actually started planning from February itself on how we can improve the overall situation of this stadium as this is a pretty old stadium. The infrastructure is obviously quite old. So we just wanted to refurbish it and also represent it as a new and good thing," SAI Executive Director Ambar Pratap Singh told reporters.

"So as you've been seeing, it's not just structural upgradation that have been done, a lot of soft upgradation has also been

done. One, I would like them to see is the lake. We have a lake and we have tried to improve it. By the start of the event, you will see a beautiful lake just across the stadium. These are some of the soft upgrades that have been done along with structural upgrades where the roof was treated, a lot of expansion joints were treated. A lot of chairs are new, many of them have been rubbed and polished properly. The buildings have been painted. As far as the pigeons are concerned, there was concern inside the arena. We have introduced innovative ways to deal with it." "It includes machines which have been imported from the US. It has also to do with a lot of non-toxic gel, a technology which repels pigeons," he said.

AGENCIES

Pragg to meet Samuel in first round of the Sinquefield Cup

ST. LOUIS: In high spirits after his victory in the St. Louis Rapid and Blitz, which elevated him to second place in the overall Grand Chess Tour rankings, R. Praggnanandhaa, barring a debacle here, is likely to feature in the finale later this year.

The Grand Chess Tour (GCT) Finals are contested by the top-four finishers on the tour, and currently, American Grandmaster Fabiano Caruana is ahead of Praggnanandhaa.

Samuel Sevian is a surprise entry in the Sinquefield Cup, after French Grandmaster Alireza Firouzja decided to withdraw from the tour.

All nine regular tour play-



ers will be back in the Sinquefield Cup, making it one of the strongest tournaments of the year, alongside the Norway Chess Classic, which was also won by Praggnanandhaa.

Caruana starts as the favourite yet again, as classical chess is his forte, while fellow Americans, Wesley So and Levon Aronian, will also be among the contenders for a podium finish.

AGENCIES

From laidback to fired-up: Shetty ready for World C'ships debut

NEW DELHI: Young Indian shuttler Ayush Shetty on Monday said he has been working to shed his "natural laid-back approach" to become a more aggressive player as he gears up for a tough World Championships debut in which his opening match is against current No. 1 Shi Yuqi of China.

Unseeded Shetty said he was mentally prepared for such a possibility and feels better prepared to face the Chinese when the event gets underway here from August 17.

"I was watching the draw live. As soon as I got it with Shi, I was ready. As I was unseeded, I was prepared to play world No. 1. I didn't have much of a reaction, it is just another match, really tough battle," Shetty said during a virtual



interaction.

The world number 23 Indian has lost to Shi three times, including in the final of the Asian Badminton Championships, but feels those defeats have provided him valuable lessons ahead of their next meeting.

"I think definitely I have lost three times. I had some good learning, also ABC final. The

tactical aspect of the game, he was much better, but we have been working hard. I feel stronger," he said.

"I think he is a really tough opponent. I remember ABC final, he was really prepared. I have gotten better, I have been analysing the match, and also the mental aspect. You have to really work hard against him."

AGENCIES

Mohun Bagan storm into Durand Cup quarters

NEW DELHI: Mohun Bagan Super Giant stormed into the quarter-finals of the 135th Durand Cup with a commanding 6-0 win over CISF Protectors, here on Monday.

Sahal Abdul Samad was the star of the show, scoring a first-half hat-trick (17', 19', 37'), while Manvir Singh (24'), Jamie MacLaren (68') and Tekcham Abhishek Singh (73') also found the scoresheet. The victory sees Mohun Bagan finish top of Group A with a perfect nine points, while CISF Protectors exit without a point. Already assured of a quarter-final berth, Mohun Bagan showed their attacking intent from the outset.

AGENCIES

DAVIS CUP Dhamne earns maiden call-up for Korea tie



NEW DELHI: Manas Dhamne on Monday earned his first call-up to India's main Davis Cup squad, while the team management has retained the core that produced a historic win over the Netherlands for the crucial Qualifiers Round 2 tie against South Korea in Seoul on September 18-19.

World number 362 and country's number two singles player Dhamne has been knocking on the doors of the senior team. He joins India's singles group comprising seasoned campaigner Sumit Nagal (ranked 235) and Dhakshinewar Suresh (Ranked 393), the breakout star of the previous tie in Bengaluru.

Yuki Bhambri (Ranked 28) and N Sriram Balaji (Ranked 57) form the doubles combination.

Sidharth Rawat (536) and promising youngster Arnav Paparkar, who has been competing in junior G'Rand Slams, have been named as the two reserves. "Most players selected themselves. Manas was not available for the previous tie, this

Squad

SINGLES: Sumit Nagal, Dhakshinewar Suresh, Manas Dhamne

DOUBLES: Yuki Bhambri, N Sriram Balaji

RESERVES: Arnav Paparkar, Sidharth Rawat

time he was. While he is in the main squad, the captain will decide if he suits the conditions or the other singles players. Arnav is in side as we need to groom the future generation," a selection committee member told PTI.

The selection reflects continuity after India's remarkable 3-2 victory over the Netherlands in Bengaluru in February, which took the country into the second round of the Qualifiers for the first time since the Davis Cup format was revamped in 2019. Dhamne's inclusion is the only major change to the main squad, with Nagal, Suresh, Bhambri and Balaji retaining their places.

AGENCIES

M.P. POWER GENERATING COMPANY LIMITED
Office of The Addl. C.E. (P&W), Shree Singaji Thermal Power Project, Dongalia Distt. Khandwa (M.P.) E-mail ID : sepnw.sstpp1@gmail.com
No. 515-1700/SSTPP/MPPGCL/P&W/3855
Date : 10.08.2026

Tender Particulars/Tender Number	Estimated Cost (Rs.) (including GST)	Tender Cost & EMD in Rs.	Last Date and Time for Closing of Online Submission
Procurement of AR/GR/Exceller grade Ammonia solution (complying with IS 799 2023 with up-to-date amendments as when updated by BIS) in 25 litre pack for all TPSs of MPPGCL on open tender basis with limited make i.e. Merck/Aventor/Thermofisher Scientific Pvt Ltd./Pioneer Chemicals, Nagpur/Aqua Chemicals and Gases Pvt. Ltd. Only (T-2026_MPPGC_518436_1)	Rs. 1,01,56,000/- (Including G.S.T.)	5000/- & 2,00,000/-	15.09.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs.
Annual work contract for Housekeeping and cleaning services of TG Building, Service Building and its associated of Unit 3 and 4, PH-2 at 2x660 MW, SSTPP, MPPGCL, Dongalia (T-2026_MPPGC_474072_1)	Rs. 52,66,050/- (Including G.S.T.)	2000/- & 1,05,321/-	13.08.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs.

For extension & other details, the bidders are requested to please visit e-portal of GoMP at www.mptenders.gov.in
M.P. Madhyam/127477/2026 // SAVE ELECTRICITY // SE (P&W)

GODREJ FINANCE LIMITED
Registered office at Godrej One, Pirojshanagar, Eastern Express Highway, Vikhroli (East) Mumbai-400079 Maharashtra
Branch Office: Godrej Capital, R-5, Green Park (M), Near Haldiram's, New Delhi 110016

DEMAND NOTICE
Under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation And Reconstruction of Financial Assets And Enforcement Of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with Rule 3 (1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. The undersigned is the Authorised Officer of Godrej Finance Limited under Securitisation And Reconstruction Of Financial Assets And Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (the said Act). In exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, the Authorised Officer has issued Demand Notices under section 13(2) of the said Act, calling upon the following Borrower(s) (the "said Borrower(s)"), to repay the amounts mentioned in the respective Demand Notice(s) issued to them that are also given below. In connection with above, Notice is hereby given, once again, to the said Borrower(s) to pay to Godrej Finance Limited, within 60 days from the publication of this Notice, the amounts indicated herein below, together with further interest as detailed in the said Demand Notice(s), from the date(s) mentioned below till the date of payment and/or realization, payable under the loan agreement read with other documents/writings, if any, executed by the said Borrower(s). As security for due repayment of the loan, the following assets have been mortgaged to Godrej Finance Limited by the said Borrower(s) respectively.

Name of the Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Loan Account Number	Demand Notice Date, Amount and NPA Date	Description of secured asset (immovable property)
1. M/s. G.M. GARMENTS (Applicant / Borrower) First Floor, 6106, Gali No. 7, Block No. 1-b, Dev Nagar, Karol Bagh, New Delhi, Delhi, 110005	05.08.2026, Rs.1,83,48,907/- (INR One Crore Eighty Three Lakhs Forty Eight Thousand Nine Hundred and Seven Only) 4.08.2026	Property being Freehold bearing Municipal No. 6106, Entire First Floor without its roof rights, Built on Plot No. 135/1, Khasra No. 4014/135, situated at Block no. 1-B, Gali no. 7, Padam Singh Road, Dev Nagar, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005 and the boundaries for the same are:- East: NA West: NA North : NA South : NA
2. Mrs. Sheela Devi (Applicant / Borrower) Plot No-30, 31, Block-L2, Near Geeta Mandir, Mohan Garden, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi, Delhi 110059		
3. M/s. S D FABRICS (Applicant / Borrower) Mezzanine Floor, 6106, Block No. 1-b, Gali Number -7, Dev Nagar, New Delhi, Delhi, 110005		
4. Mr. Bhairav Mahto (Applicant / Borrower) Plot No-30, 31, Block-L2, Near Geeta Mandir, Mohan Garden, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi, Delhi 110059		

If the said Borrowers shall fail to make payment to Godrej Finance Limited as aforesaid, Godrej Finance Limited shall proceed against the above secured assets under Section 13(4) of the Act and the applicable Rules, entirely at the risks of the said Borrowers as to the costs and consequences. The said Borrowers are prohibited under the Act from transferring the aforesaid assets, whether by way of sale, lease or otherwise without the prior written consent of Godrej Finance Limited. Any person who contravenes or abets contravention of the provisions of the said Act or Rules made there under, shall be liable for imprisonment and/or penalty as provided under the Act.

Date: August 11, 2026, Place: New Delhi (Authorised Officer), Godrej Finance Limited

GODREJ FINANCE LIMITED
Registered office at Godrej One, Pirojshanagar, Eastern Express Highway, Vikhroli (East) Mumbai-400079 Maharashtra
Branch Office: Godrej Capital, R-5, Green Park (M), Near Haldiram's, New Delhi-110016

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Name of the Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Loan Account Number	Demand Notice Date, Amount and NPA Date	Description of secured asset (immovable property)
1. M/s. Toto Enterprises (Applicant/ Borrower) Basement Back Portion, Plot No. 212, Block A, DSIDC Industrial Area, Narela, New Delhi- 110040. 2. Mrs. Guddi (Co-Applicant / Co-Borrower) W/o Mr. Krishan Gopal Plot No. 37, 3rd Floor, PKT- 8, Near Main Road, Rohini Sector 21, Sultanpuri C Block, New Delhi-110086. 3. Mr. Yogesh Pal (Co-Applicant/Co-Borrower) S/o Mr. Krishan Gopal Plot No. 37, 3rd Floor, PKT - 8, Near Main Road, Rohini Sector 21, Sultanpuri C Block, New Delhi-110086. Loan Account No. GFL3101LP0034731	05.08.2026, Rs. 98,42,305/- (INR Ninety Eight Lakhs Forty Two Thousand Three Hundred and Five Only) 04.08.2026	Property Being Residential Bearing Entire Third Floor With Roof Weights, Area Measuring 90 Sq. Mtrs. Built Upon On The Property Bearing No. 37, Pocket 8, Sector 21, Rohini, New Delhi

If the said Borrowers shall fail to make payment to Godrej Finance Limited as aforesaid, Godrej Finance Limited shall proceed against the above secured assets under Section 13(4) of the Act and the applicable Rules, entirely at the risks of the said Borrowers as to the costs and consequences. The said Borrowers are prohibited under the Act from transferring the aforesaid assets, whether by way of sale, lease or otherwise without the prior written consent of Godrej Finance Limited. Any person who contravenes or abets contravention of the provisions of the said Act or Rules made there under, shall be liable for imprisonment and/or penalty as provided under the Act.

Date: August 11, 2026, Place: New Delhi (Authorised Officer), Godrej Finance Limited

HIMACHAL PRADESH JAL SHAKTI VIBHAG "NOTICE INVITING TENDER"

Online bids on item rate basis are invited by the Executive Engineer, Jal Shakti Division, ReckongPeeo on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh in electronic tendering system in two covers for the under mentioned work from the contractor/firms enlisted with Himachal Pradesh Jal Shakti Vibhag HP as per his/her class of enlistment in appropriate class.

Sr. No.	Name of work	Estimated Cost	Earnest Money	Cost of form	Time
1	Remodeling of FIS Bokti in Tehsil Kalpa Distt. Kinnaur (H.P.) (SH-C/O RCC Channel for Kuhl from RD 7638 to RD 9451, C/O P.C.C. 8/Wall at RD 9175 to RD 9210 and C/O R.C.C. R/Wall at RD 9325 to RD 9345)	Rs. 21131663/-	Rs. 286317/-	Rs 7000/-	One year
2	Remodelling of FIS Bokti in Tehsil Kalpa Distt. Kinnaur (H.P.) (SH-C/O RCC Channel for Kuhl from RD 9451 to RD 11265 and C/O P.C.C. 8/Wall at RD 11090 to RD 11120)	Rs. 19671408	Rs. 271714	Rs.5000/-	One year

1. Tender documents and other instructions can be downloaded or viewed online from the portal <http://hptenders.gov.in> by the firms/individual registered on the website which is free of cost.
2. As the bids are to be submitted online are required to be encrypted and digitally signed, the bidders are advised to obtain Digital Signature Certificate (DSC) from suitable vendors or from any authorized agency at the earliest.

3. KEY DATES:-

1	Date of online publication	7/08/2026 upto 5.00 PM
2	Downloading of e-tender documents	08/08/2026 at 10.00 AM to 17/08/2026 upto 5.00PM
3	Date of submission of e-tendering	08/08/2026 at 10.00 AM to 17/08/2026 upto 5.00PM
4	submission of earnest money deposit and cost form through online mode (e-payment)	Upto 17/08/2026 5.00 PM
5	Date of opening bid	18/08/2026 at 11.00 AM (16/8/2026 Sunday)
	Cover-1 eligibility criteria	18/08/2026 at 11.00 AM
	Cover-2 Financial Bid	Should be intimated Separately.

CONDITIONS:-
1. The e-tender documents shall be uploaded online in 2 (two) covers:-
i) Cover-1 shall contain scanned copies of "eligibility information".
ii) Cover-2 shall contain "Financial Bid" on the prescribed form
Ro.No 2549/2026-2027

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
(See Section 84-Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely Tarun S/o Lt. Surender R/o H.No. 11/580, RR Block Navan Shahadara, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case e-FIR No. 80028525/2026 U/s 304(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023 at P.S. Sarai Rohila, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Tarun cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Tarun have absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused Tarun of e-FIR No. 80028525/2026 U/s 304 (2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023 at P.S.: Sarai Rohila, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 14.09.2026.
By order
Rangat Ghirra
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04
Central District, Room No. 37,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi
DP/11117/N/2026

R Madhavan opened up about criticisms of the ‘Dhurandhar’ franchise and ‘Rocketry: The Nambi Effect’

‘EVERYBODY IS A PRODUCT of their conditioning’



Although director Aditya Dhar's Ranveer Singh-starrer 'Dhurandhar' (2025) and its sequel, 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge' (2026), became massive blockbusters, entering the Rs 1,000 crore club individually, they opened to polarised reviews. While some hailed the spy-action thrillers as masterpieces, others criticised the films as propaganda vehicles that allegedly attempted to whitewash the government's missteps.

Recently, R Madhavan, who played a pivotal role in the franchise, responded to the criticisms. "Everybody is a product of their conditioning. From a young age, I was taught that our country is the most important to us, as well as what we do for it. If you look at my social media posts or inter-

He maintained that such comments people make on social media do not influence his decisions

views, you can see that I have never spoken ill of any political party, politician or political leader. If someone does something good, like Stalin sir (former Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin), for instance, I praise them immediately," he pointed out during a conversation with 'Galatta Plus'.

He continued, "I have decided that I will do only good and if I have doubts about something, I won't talk about it. When an elected politician becomes a Prime Minister or a Chief Minister, I believe it is my duty to support them. To date, no party - be it Tamil Nadu or at the national level - has approached me asking me to promote them or inviting me to join them."

The actor-filmmaker maintained that such comments people make on social media do not influence his decisions, as he sees them as nothing more than expressions of frustration. "If something good is happening in our country... For instance, if I post about a sportsperson who is performing well and bringing the nation fame, that's because I feel that's the right thing to do. If someone's making me feel bad about that, then I will question their intent," Madhavan pointed out.

The interviewer further noted that while 'Dhurandhar' was labelled 'propaganda' by some, 'Rocketry: The Nambi Effect' (2022), had also faced similar criticisms.

AGENCIES

25 years on, ‘Dil Chahta Hai’ still gets friendship right

In an age of reels, Akash, Sid and Sameer remind us what real friendships look like



Farhan Akhtar's 2001 debut directorial taught a generation that friendship can survive distance, differences and ego

Humein har saal ek hafte ke liye Goa aana chahiye," Akash (Aamir Khan) said. Sid responded rather calmly, "Lekin kiski zindagi kisey kaha le jaati hai kya pata! Kabhi socha hai ke shayad har saal yaha aana toh ek taraf, dass saal mein ek baar bhi milna mushkil ho!" That dialogue between the three friends on Chapora Fort from 'Dil Chahta Hai' hits hardest for millennials like this correspondent.

When Farhan Akhtar's directorial debut was released in 2001, many were in school. The film inspired youngsters to plan Goa trips. Many fulfilled them and many couldn't (like this correspondent). Years later, when she visited Chapora Fort, where the iconic scene was shot, she had not met her best friends in years. They were settled across the country, some abroad. Yet, as Akash and Sameer assured Sid, friendship remained.

'Dil Chahta Hai' was a textbook on friendship. Akhtar's film taught that friends remain united despite differences and distance. Friendships, like life, can be flawed. Friendship



needs no constant update, nor does a friend's 'aura' always have to match yours. The film follows three friends who are as different as chalk and cheese. Akash is stubborn, outspoken and hides behind humour; Sameer is a hopeless romantic who often behaves immaturely; Sid is calm, sensitive and more mature. It is about growing up, drifting apart and rediscovering.

The film shows how ego can damage relationships, as it does between Akash and Sid. But sometimes, a simple apology and a hug can change everything. The hospital scene, where Akash hugs Sid when Tara (Dimple Kapadia) is unwell, remains one of the film's strongest takeaways 25 years on.

In the age of reels and constant updates, we need to make time to meet, resolve differences and say what we want before it's too late. Even a text or 'WhatsApp' can help. Confess your love or admit when you are wrong before there is no chance left.

'Dil Chahta Hai' also speaks about letting go. The harder we hold on, the more they may slip away. In Goa, Deepa (Samantha Tremayne), who runs after "Aakaaashh", tells Sid about her feelings. Sid tells her that sand slips away when held too tightly. It teaches us to let go of those who do not want to stay.

Every day on 'Facebook', we receive endless friendship requests. But nothing comes close to old friends: those who watched us grow and know our deepest secrets and harshest sides. They have seen us at our worst and best. We may not meet or speak often and may forget to call. But when we are down, they are often the first to rush to our side. They have seen us through it all. That's what 'Dil Chahta Hai' keeps teaching us even after 25 years. So, call those old friends. Make that Goa plan. The plans that never materialised in school or college might work out now.

Sanjay reveals shocking aftermath of ‘Sirf Tum’

The 1999 film emerged as a major success



Looking back at his career, he believes the industry has changed significantly

Sanjay Kapoor is perhaps the only member of the Kapoor family whose career never reached the heights of his actor brother Anil Kapoor or producer brother Boney Kapoor. While his 1999 film 'Sirf Tum' emerged as a major success, the actor claimed it did not translate into the kind of opportunities one would expect from a hit. According to him, no producer approached him with a film offer immediately after its success. Although Sanjay went on to appear in several films, none established him as a consistently bankable leading star.

Looking back at his career, the actor now believes the industry has changed significantly. He feels that actors who deliver a few hits today can secure lucrative opportunities for years, something he said was not the case during his time. In his career as a leading actor, 'Raja' and 'Sirf Tum' ulti-

mately remained his two major box-office successes.

Speaking to 'Digital Commentary', Sanjay said, "'Sirf Tum' was such a huge hit that today, even after 27 years, we are talking about it. But look at my destiny, I didn't sign a single film after 'Sirf Tum'. Today, if people give three hits, their career is set for 25 years. They bag several ads. They start earning in crores just after one big hit."

Expressing his disbelief over the lack of offers following 'Sirf Tum's' success, he added, "People praised that film so much, but I don't know what went wrong that nobody ever approached me after that. Nobody signed me. I didn't receive any good offers. I won't lie that I was loaded with projects and I declined. I had limited offers, but they were not very great. I thought, I have given a hit; let me wait for something better. It is difficult to give a hit, be it now or then." AGENCIES

SAREE SASHTRA

Carrying beauty without surrendering identity

A saree has always carried power too – not through force, but through elegance and presence

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The first thing visitors met at 'Saree Shashtra' wasn't a saree. It was an ambush.

A ring of steel closed around them - spears, a mace, knives, the oldest and most literal grammar of power humanity has ever spoken. And at the centre of that ring, impossibly, hangs a single length of cloth. Fragile. Almost apologetic. The kind of thing a blade could end in one stroke.

That collision is the exhibition's opening argument: what if a shastra doesn't need to be forged from metal at all? What if the fiercer, more stubborn power is the one that doesn't cut - the one that simply refuses to be forgotten? A saree does not conquer. It outlasts. It holds a story across a hundred years the way no weapon ever could.

Everything the gallery showed after this was an answer to that provocation.

THE WOMAN IN THE VERSE

A few steps in, the focus shifted - from the cloth's strength to the strength of the woman wearing it. At the centre of the second installation was a line of Sanskrit: *यत्र नरं त्रु पुरुषेते सन्ते तत्र देवताः* (Where women are honoured, there the divine flourishes).

Around it, the exhibition showed the many roles a woman holds at once. Lawyer, artist, politician, singer, sportsperson and just as often, homemaker and caregiver - moving between the two without ever fully setting one down. This was where the title started to make sense. A shastra usually means knowledge or power. The exhibition stretched that meaning. A saree has always carried power too - not through force, but through elegance and presence. It doesn't need to raise its voice to be noticed.

Grace, the gallery suggested, is its own kind of strength.

WHEN THE CANVAS CAN BE WORN

Deeper into the space, the saree itself started to change.

Here, it becomes a canvas. Visitors saw 'Pichwai', 'Pattachitra', 'Gond', 'Warli', 'Aipan' and 'Sohrai' art - traditional styles from different parts of India - sitting comfortably



alongside more contemporary work. Hand-painted sarees hang next to handwoven and embroidered ones, including GI-verified weaves from across the country. It doesn't feel like browsing a rack of clothes. It feels like walking through an art gallery, except every piece on the wall can also be folded up and worn home.

THE HAND BEHIND THE CLOTH

Then the artists stepped into the frame.

In one corner, two 'Pichwai' artists from Rajasthan sat hand-painting fabric in full view of visitors, explaining the nuances of the form as their brush moved. In another, a modern artist works with carved blocks, painting postcards that visitors take home. One corner speaks a centuries-old vocabulary; the other speaks the language of contemporary hand painting. They are separated by geography and by artistic lineage and joined by a single conviction: heritage survives only where it is practised, shared and watched being made.

This is what separates 'Saree Shashtra' from a conventional textile display. The visitors were shown not only the finished work, but the hand, the skill and the long patience behind it.

A BORDER THAT ONCE CARRIED A SLOGAN

From aesthetics, the exhibition turns to history and to a chapter that is often forgotten. The saree has always carried more than colour and ornament. It has held regional identity, folklore, ritual and the accumulated technical knowledge of handloom and craft communities. In the language of the curatorial framework: every weave an archive, every motif a language, every drape an inheritance.

Then came the colonial mills. The flood of British manufactured textiles hollowed out indigenous weaving and what stood to be lost was never merely a livelihood or an industry - it was a portion of India's cultural memory. During the Swadeshi Movement of 1905, the clothes answered back. Words and symbols began to appear inside woven borders and pallus, turning handloom into a discreet instrument of resistance and national consciousness. The saree, quite literally, learned to speak.

THE CONVERSATION CONTINUES

The exhibition doesn't leave its visitor in the past. Its programme

of conversations brings the subject firmly into the present, with panel discussions on 'Saree as a Living Civilisational Legacy: Art, Heritage, Identity and Women's Narratives'.

Speakers include Dr Karan Singh; Mugdha Sinha, IAS; Bandana Preyashi, IAS; Rita Menon, former Textile Secretary; Dr Sanjay Kumar Manjul, ADG, ASI; Jyotsna D. Nanda, Head Communications, DS Group; Dr Promil Pande, Dean, School of Design, UID, GD Goenka University and others.

Curator-led gallery walks, live hand-painting showcases and open interactions with artists, artisans and scholars complete the design of a space intended for conversation rather than mere observation.

FULL CIRCLE

For Shikha Ajmera, Founder of 'Shikha's Kariigari', the exhibition matters most because it puts the makers, not the merchandise, at the centre of the story: "Shikha's Kariigari" has had the opportunity to showcase its work on several platforms; however, getting the opportunity to organise this exhibition at India International Centre holds a very special place for us. It is not just about showcasing the brand, but also about paying tribute to the

hard work, skill and craftsmanship of countless artists, weavers and artisans whose contributions have made India a global destination for textile heritage."

A woman-led social enterprise and contemporary art and textile practice, 'Shikha's Kariigari' works with more than 100 artists and artisans across India, drawing on traditions including 'Pattachitra', 'Pichwai', 'Warli', 'Gond' and 'Sohrai' alongside contemporary expression. Its work has previously been presented at the Indian Art, Architecture & Design Biennale, Bharat Tex, the Salar Jung Museum, IFFI and the Surajkund International Crafts Mela. For Ajmera, fabric is both canvas and archive, a way of translating cultural narrative into hand-painted work.

By the time visitors reached the far end of the gallery, the first installation had quietly changed meaning.

The spear, the mace and the knife represented one vocabulary of power. The saree represented another. Its strength is quieter and slower to notice, the ability to speak without speaking, to hold a room without raising a hand and to carry beauty and dignity across a century without surrendering its identity.